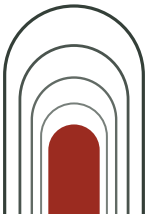
Ianua Virorum

Agnatic Recursion, Monoprosopy, and the Owed Heart in Alex Garland's Men (2022)

Toward a Theory of Agnatic Horror





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Abstract



This thesis argues that Alex Garland's *Men* (2022) is neither the transparent allegory its detractors deplored nor the hermetic puzzle its defenders celebrated, but a genealogy in the strict Nietzschean–Foucauldian sense: a descent (*Herkunft*) of patriarchal masculinity, inscribed on the body and traced through the iconographic, theological, mythological and psychoanalytic archives from which the film's images are drawn. Proceeding by Panofskian iconology and a Warburgian attention to the *Nachleben* of images, the study reconstructs the sources and analogues of the film's governing figures — the Green Man and Sheela-na-gig of the baptismal font, the apple of Genesis 3, Tertullian's *ianua diaboli*, the traducian and Augustinian theories of seminal descent, Aeschylus's embryology of the father, the Fourth Branch of the *Mabinogi*, and Ovid's Tiresias, Echo and Narcissus — and stages their encounter with psychoanalysis (Freud, Rank, Horney, Bettelheim, Klein, Lacan, Kristeva), feminist philosophy (Wollstonecraft, Woolf, Beauvoir, Irigaray, Cixous, Rich, Firestone, Sedgwick, Butler, hooks, Ahmed, Manne), feminist film theory (Mulvey, Clover, Williams, Creed), and the humanist, anti-humanist and posthumanist traditions (Protagoras, Pico della Mirandola, de Gouges, Arendt, Levinas, Foucault, Haraway, Braidotti).

From this archive the thesis constructs an original theoretical framework, *agnatic horror*, built on four concepts. *Agnatic recursion* names the reproduction of masculinity through the male line alone, without passage through the female body. *Monoprosopy* names the film's rendering of many men as a single face, which visualises at once Lacan's masculine universal, Freud's dream-condensation and the Nicene grammar of one substance in many *personae*. The *ianua virorum*, the gateway of men, names the film's relocation of Tertullian's misogynist figure from the female to the male body, which becomes the door through which violence enters history. The *Owed Heart* (*cor debitum*) names the sole issue of the male line: not a child but a claim, a demand for love that converts injury into debt and debt into female guilt.

The thesis demonstrates that the climactic chain of male births culminates not in a new life but in an invoice; that this chain is simultaneously the consummation of womb envy and a penal transfer of Eve's curse; and that what it transmits is the wound. It reads Harper's response as an ethics of *non-absolution* — a refusal of the sacerdotal role the debt assigns her, distinct both from forgiveness and from the Final Girl's counter-violence — and identifies two counter-modes of generation set against agnatic recursion: the *acoustic parthenogenesis* of the tunnel echo and the *lateral kinship* figured in Riley's arrival. It concludes by weighing the film's hazards, including its racial configuration and the essentialism its form invites, and by proposing agnatic horror as a genre-mode legible from *Kind Hearts and Coronets* (1949) to *The Shining* (1980).

The Plural of Man



The grammar of a title

The title of Alex Garland's third feature as director is a single plural noun, unmodified by article, adjective or predicate, and it is the most compressed statement of the film's argument. *Men* descends from Old English *menn*, the plural of *mann*, a word that designated a human being irrespective of sex; the sexes were marked by *wer* and *wīf*, and by the compounds *wǣpnedmann* and *wīfmann* (whence "woman"), which specified male and female persons within a common genus. The narrowing of *man* to the male, together with the stubborn retention of its universal sense, is the philological sediment of the asymmetry Simone de Beauvoir diagnosed in 1949: the masculine occupies at once the positive and the neutral pole, so that a single word names both a sex and the species (Beauvoir 1949). Garland's title performs at the level of the signifier the operation his film performs at the level of the image. It decomposes the humanist universal, *Man*, into its sexed particular, *men*; and it recomposes that particular as a universal, a single face distributed across an entire village.

The grammar is apt in a second and more literal sense. *Men* is an umlaut plural, formed not by the addition of a suffix but by a mutation within the body of the singular, the root vowel fronted under the pressure of a lost inflection. The plural of *man* is a metamorphosis of *man*. The film's plurality is formed in exactly this way. Its many men are not added to one another; they are produced by the mutation of one body, Rory Kinnear's, into landlord, vicar, constable, publican,

drinker, boy and wild man, and finally by a chain of births in which each body opens to deliver the next. The title is therefore not a label affixed to the film but its first image: a word that already contains the history of a universal becoming particular and of a particular passing itself off as universal.

The film

Men was written and directed by Garland, produced by DNA Films, photographed by Rob Hardy and scored by Geoff Barrow and Ben Salisbury. It was released by A24 in the United States on 20 May 2022, screened in the Directors' Fortnight at Cannes two days later, and opened in the United Kingdom on 1 June 2022; Cotson, its fictional Herefordshire village, was filmed at Withington in Gloucestershire, with the tunnel sequence shot in the Forest of Dean (Wikipedia). The diegetic county matters more than the production geography. Herefordshire is Marcher country, the borderland of England and Wales, and it holds at Kilpeck the most celebrated Sheela-na-gig in England; the film's iconography is thus local before it is archetypal.

Harper Marlowe (Jessie Buckley) retreats to a rented manor in Cotson after the death of her husband, James (Paapa Essiedu). The end of the marriage is reconstructed in shards of flashback: Harper's announcement that she intends to divorce him; James's threat to kill himself if she does; the blow he strikes to her face; her locking him out of their London flat; and his fall from the balcony above, past her window and onto the railings below, where he is partially impaled, his forearm ruptured. The film's first image of grief is thus also its first image of a fall, and the two will not be separated again.

In Cotson she is received by Geoffrey, the landlord, whose mock-stern reproof when she eats an apple from the garden tree, withdrawn at once as a joke, supplies the film's first theological cue. A walk carries her through woodland to a disused railway tunnel, where she sings and her voice returns to her as harmony, until a figure at the far end begins to scream and run toward her. From an open field she photographs the landscape and finds, inside the image, a naked man watching her. He reappears in her garden, his face scored with bloody scratches, and thrusts his hand through the letterbox; he is arrested and released. In the church, whose font bears a carved Green Man and Sheela-na-gig, she meets a boy wearing a mask of a platinum-blonde screen siren, who calls her a "stupid bitch" when she declines to play with him, and a vicar who suggests that she bears part of the responsibility for James's death, having denied him the chance to apologise. In the pub, the landlord and his patrons wear Geoffrey's face, as does the

constable who reports the naked man's release; the only other woman glimpsed in the village, a police officer, appears briefly, and the arrest she helps to make is promptly undone.

Night falls as a sequence of intrusions. A crow breaks a kitchen window, and Geoffrey, arriving to help, kills it by wringing its neck. The naked man reaches again through the letterbox; Harper drives a knife through his forearm, which, as he withdraws it, splits along its length in the wound James bore. The boy and the vicar appear inside the house bearing the same wound; the vicar, whose advances are framed by an allusion to Yeats's "Leda and the Swan", attempts to rape her, and she stabs him. Fleeing by car, she strikes Geoffrey, who seizes the vehicle and pursues her until he crashes. The naked man returns in the full foliate form of the Green Man, his ankle now broken as James's was, and gives birth to the boy, who gives birth to the vicar, who gives birth to Geoffrey, who gives birth to James. Harper, an axe in her hands, sits beside her reborn husband on the sofa and asks what he wants from her. He answers that he wants her love. In the morning Riley, Harper's friend, who is pregnant, follows a trail of blood and finds Harper, who smiles.

Reception and the problem of the obvious

The film's critical reception divided around a single complaint in several dialects: that its meaning was too available. Peter Bradshaw found it unsubtle and schematic; Clarisse Loughrey judged it pseudo-feminist, a film that mistook the depiction of male misconduct for thought about it; K. Austin Collins argued that in reminding its audience that men are awful it forgot the woman at its centre; Kevin Maher held that its birthing sequence was itself aggressively misogynistic; Armond White read it through the 2018 Senate hearings at which Christine Blasey Ford testified that Brett Kavanaugh had sexually assaulted her when both were teenagers, an allegation Kavanaugh denied (reception summarised in Wikipedia). Audiences polled by CinemaScore awarded it a D+. Garland, for his part, publicly declined to fix its meaning.

The convergence is instructive. The charge of obviousness and the charge of incoherence are one charge seen from opposite sides, for both presuppose that the film is an allegory in the vulgar sense: a code whose key is either too easily found ("men are bad") or never found at all. This thesis rejects that presupposition. Barthes taught that the obvious is the home of ideology, the region of what-goes-without-saying in which history disguises itself as nature (Barthes 1957); Shklovsky taught that art exists to make the stone stony, to restore

the perceptibility of what habit has rendered invisible (Shklovsky 1917). *Men* is obvious in the way a diagram is obvious: it renders a structure so insistently that the structure, ordinarily dissolved into the texture of everyday life, becomes strange. Its obviousness is not a failure of depth but its technique of estrangement, and the critical task is not to decode it but to trace where its images come from and what they carry with them.

Method

The thesis proceeds by four interlocking methods. The first is iconology. Erwin Panofsky's three strata of interpretation, pre-iconographic description, iconographic analysis and iconological interpretation, furnish the discipline by which a carved font or a foliate face is read before it is theorised (Panofsky 1939). Aby Warburg's concept of the *Nachleben*, the afterlife of images, and his *Pathosformeln*, the charged formulae in which emotion survives across centuries, supply the historical dimension; the font of Cotson's church functions as a single panel of a Warburgian atlas, on which the Romanesque, the patristic and the pagan are pinned side by side (Warburg 1924–29). That Garland trained as an art historian makes the method more than a convenience.

The second method is genealogy. Nietzsche's *Genealogy of Morality* (1887) and Foucault's reading of it distinguish the search for an origin (*Ursprung*), a pure and essential beginning, from the tracing of a descent (*Herkunft*), the accidental, embodied and often humiliating history by which a value comes to be (Foucault 1971). Foucault insists that descent attaches itself to the body, which he calls the inscribed surface of events. The climactic chain of births in *Men* is genealogy in this sense made literal: a descent passed from body to body, each bearing the wounds of its predecessor, with no pure origin at its head. The third method is psychoanalytic-feminist film theory, from Laura Mulvey and Carol Clover to Barbara Creed and Linda Williams, read against its sources in Freud, Lacan and Kristeva. The fourth is structural and comparative mythography, after Lévi-Strauss and Nicole Loraux, which allows the film's births to be read alongside the autochthony myths of Athens, the embryology of Aeschylus, the *Mabinogi* and Ovid.

These methods are held together by the figure Walter Benjamin and Theodor Adorno called the constellation: an arrangement of elements whose figure appears only when they are seen together, and which no single element contains (Benjamin 1928; Adorno 1966). The question of authorial intention is bracketed accordingly. Nothing in the argument depends on Garland having read Tertullian

or the Fourth Branch of the *Mabinogi*; the argument depends on the images having descended from the archives in which those texts also stand. Where the film explicitly cites a source, the font, the apple, Yeats, the citation is marked as such; elsewhere sources are offered as analogues, and their force is analytic rather than biographical (Wimsatt and Beardsley 1946; Barthes 1967).

Thesis and plan

The thesis advanced here is that *Men* is a genealogy of *agnatic recursion*: the reproduction of masculinity through the male line alone, without passage through the female body. Its formal correlate is *monoprosopy*, the rendering of many men as one face. Its theological correlate is the *ianua virorum*, the relocation of Tertullian's "devil's gateway" from woman to man, whose body becomes the door through which violence enters history. Its affective product is the *Owed Heart*, the demand for love in which the male line terminates. Against this structure Harper practises *non-absolution*, and the film sets two counter-generations, the *acoustic parthenogenesis* of the echo and the *lateral kinship* of Riley's arrival.

Chapter One reads the Garland corpus as a sustained inquiry into reproduction without the mother. Chapter Two reconstructs the iconography of the font: the Green Man, the wild man, the Sheela-na-gig, baptism as clerical birth, and the Welsh matrix of the *Mabinogi*. Chapter Three follows the Fall through Genesis, Tertullian, the traducian and Augustinian theories of descent, and the Greek myths of autochthony. Chapter Four reads the births as the consummation and the punishment of womb envy, through Freud, Kristeva, Creed, Horney, Bettelheim, Theweleit, Lacan and Ovid. Chapter Five places the film among the feminist traditions it answers and is answered by. Chapter Six measures it against humanism, anti-humanism and posthumanism. Chapter Seven sets out, in twelve theses, a theory of agnatic horror; a conclusion weighs the film's limits and the theory's reach.

Chapter One

Genesis Without the Mother

The Garland Corpus as a Theory of Non-Sexual Reproduction



Across three decades of fiction and film, Garland has returned with unusual consistency to a single problem: how life, or something that passes for it, might be generated without the mother. *Men* is the point at which that problem sheds its alibis of technology, contagion and science fiction and turns upon masculinity itself.

1.1 Constellation, not cause

Garland was born in London in 1970, the son of the political cartoonist Nicholas Garland and the psychoanalyst Caroline Medawar, and the grandson of Sir Peter Medawar, who shared the 1960 Nobel Prize in Physiology or Medicine with Macfarlane Burnet for the discovery of acquired immunological tolerance. These facts are offered as a constellation, not a cause. Immunology defines the organism by its capacity to distinguish self from non-self, and Medawar's experiments demonstrated that this boundary is learned rather than given: an immune system exposed early enough to foreign tissue will tolerate it as its own (Billingham, Brent and Medawar 1953). Roberto Esposito later generalised the immunitary paradigm into a theory of modern politics, in which communities preserve themselves by incorporating controlled doses of what threatens them (Esposito 2002).

Men is legible as an immunological horror. The village's men recognise one another as self, for they share a face, and recognise Harper as non-self. Its

institutions tolerate the naked intruder, whom the police release, while mounting something like an inflammatory response against the woman who reported him. The film's governing image, the same face appearing wherever the other should be, is in these terms an autoimmune image: a social body that has learned to treat the invader as self and the self's most vulnerable member as foreign.

The psychoanalytic inheritance is more direct. The film's formal grammar is that of the dream-work as Freud described it, condensation, displacement and regard for representability (Freud 1900). Freud observes that the dream can construct collective and composite figures (*Sammel- und Mischpersonen*), in which several persons are fused into one, and that the dreamer typically accepts such absurdities without remark. Harper never comments on the men's resemblance. Chapter Four argues that this condensation belongs to the film rather than merely to its heroine's mind; here it suffices to note that the analytic idiom is native to the work. Garland's undergraduate training in art history at Manchester supplies the third element of the constellation, an iconographic intelligence that treats images as documents with lineages.

1.2 The novels: enclosure and self-perpetuation

The Beach (1996) concerns an enclosed community on a Thai island, a backpackers' utopia that degenerates as the collective comes to prefer its own perpetuation to the lives of its members. Its narrator's imagination is saturated by the cinema of the Vietnam War, so that his masculinity arrives pre-mediated, a citation of citations; its lineage runs back to Golding's *Lord of the Flies* (1954), the canonical English fable of an all-male society's regression. The early Garland, however, does not sex his violence: the commune is led by a woman, Sal, whose decisions are among its most ruthless. *The Tesseract* (1998) disperses a single night in Manila across converging perspectives, and *The Coma* (2004), whose protagonist lies unconscious after a violent confrontation on a train, is illustrated with woodcuts by Nicholas Garland and constitutes the author's most sustained exercise in dream logic before *Men*. Its world dissolves identity into recursion; *Men* will dissolve identity into a lineage.

1.3 *28 Days Later* and the promise of women

Garland's screenplay for Danny Boyle's *28 Days Later* (2002) introduces the two figures that *Men* will fuse: replication and the country house. The Rage virus reproduces as viruses do, by copying itself through hosts, without union and without difference. The film's final movement relocates horror from the infected

to the soldiers garrisoned in a requisitioned mansion, whose commander, Major West, has promised his men women and intends to hand over the two who arrive, Selena and Hannah, a teenage girl, for his soldiers to rape, which he defends as the precondition of repopulating the country. Rape is claimed in the language of reproduction, and the women are treated as the future's raw material. The protagonist rescues them only by becoming indistinguishable from the infected, the first of Garland's monstrous doubles. *Men* is the second Garland film in which a country house becomes the theatre of a male collective's claim upon a woman, and the first in which the collective dispenses with her body as the medium of its continuation.

1.4 *Never Let Me Go*: the clone and the humanist test

Garland's adaptation of Kazuo Ishiguro's novel (2005; film dir. Mark Romanek, 2010) concerns clones raised to donate their organs until they "complete". They cannot have children; their art is collected to test whether they have souls; and in one of the novel's most delicate motifs they search magazines and strangers' faces for their "possibles", the originals from whom they were copied. The clone seeks the single face from which it descends. The men of Cotson never seek it, because they are it. Where Ishiguro poses the humanist question in its classical form, whether the copy has an interior, *Men* poses its inverse: whether a plurality of men amounts to a plurality of persons at all.

1.5 *Ex Machina*: Pandora, Pygmalion and the imitation game

Ex Machina (2014) restages the oldest myth of motherless genesis in Western literature. Hesiod's Pandora, the first woman, is not born but manufactured by Hephaestus at Zeus's command, a *kalon kakon*, a beautiful evil delivered to men as their punishment (*Theogony* 570–612). Ovid's Pygmalion carves his ivory woman because he is revolted by real ones (*Metamorphoses* X.243–297). Nathan keeps one of his gynoids, Kyoko, as a mute servant whom he also uses sexually, and stores his discarded prototypes in closets that recall Bluebeard's chamber. Ava, with Kyoko's help, stabs him to death and escapes, sealing her male tester inside the house. The film composes a feminist reversal of the Pygmalion fantasy, in which the made woman refuses to complete her maker's desire and kills the maker.

The film's governing test has a buried history that bears directly on *Men*. Turing's 1950 paper introduces the imitation game not as a contest between human and machine but between a man and a woman: an interrogator must determine which is the woman, and the man's object is to deceive (Turing 1950).

Only then does Turing ask what happens when a machine takes the man's part. The founding test of machine intelligence is thus a test of a man's capacity to pass as a woman. *Ex Machina* reverses it: a machine built as a woman passes a man's test by exploiting his desire. *Men* completes the circuit. The boy behind the mask of a platinum-blonde screen siren is Turing's first player, a male body passing through the most iconic mask of manufactured femininity, and Kinnear's polymorphism is the imitation game generalised, one man imitating everyone. *Ex Machina* is generation without the mother by *technē*; *Men* is generation without the mother by flesh.

1.6 *Annihilation*: refraction, the ouroboros and the returning husband

Annihilation (2018), freely adapted from Jeff VanderMeer's novel (2014), opens with its heroine, the cell biologist Lena, lecturing on cell division: the first image of a cinema in which life proceeds by division rather than union. The Shimmer refracts genetic material as a prism refracts light, producing hybrids, mutations and doubles; an ouroboros tattoo migrates from body to body; and Lena's husband, Kane, returns from the zone as a replica. Recovered video shows the original Kane charging his double to find his wife and then killing himself with a phosphorus grenade. The film binds his self-destruction to Lena's guilt over an affair, and it ends with her embracing the copy, her own irises shimmering.

The structural parallel is close enough that *Men* reads as a palinode, a formal retraction, of the earlier film. In both, a woman is made to carry the guilt of a male partner's suicide, actual or apparent, after a breach she initiated, adultery in one case and divorce in the other. In both, the man returns as a copy produced by a non-sexual process, refraction in one and male birth in the other. In both, the final scene places the woman beside the replica. *Annihilation* ends in an embrace whose ambiguity is ontological: is she, too, a copy? *Men* ends in an interrogation whose answer is affective and economic, and in a woman who meets the morning, and another woman, with a smile. Where *Annihilation* receives the returning husband, *Men* asks what he wants and is handed the bill.

The term palinode is chosen with care. Its archetype is Stesichorus's retraction of his blame of Helen, preserved by Socrates in the *Phaedrus* (243a–b): blinded for slandering her, the poet recovered his sight by declaring that Helen never went to Troy and that only her *eidolon*, her phantom double, did. The founding palinode of European poetry exonerates a woman blamed for a male catastrophe by means of a theory of the double. Helen is the daughter of Leda and the swan. *Men*, whose

vicar frames his attempted rape of Harper with Yeats's sonnet on the swan's rape of Leda, stands in the same tradition: it retracts the blame laid upon a woman by distributing the man across his doubles.

1.7 *Devs*: determinism and the woman who declines the script

Devs (2020) concerns a technology founder, Forest, who builds a quantum machine to project past and future, driven by grief for his dead daughter, whom he wishes to recover in simulation: paternity as computation, resurrection without the mother. Its climax turns on a woman, Lily, whom the machine predicts will shoot Forest. She throws the gun away. The act is minimal, almost anti-climactic, and it is the only event in the series that the system cannot foresee. Lily's freedom consists not in heroic counter-action but in declining the role a male system has written for her, and in this she prefigures Harper's non-absolution more exactly than any Final Girl.

1.8 After *Men*: the persistence of the male collective

The films that follow extend the inquiry. *Civil War* (2024) places two women photographers as witnesses to armed masculinity, whose signature interrogation demands to know what kind of American its captives are and ends with a soldier shooting those whose answers mark them as foreign: an interpellation enforced by a rifle. *Warfare* (2025), co-directed with Ray Mendoza, renders a platoon in an occupied Iraqi house in something close to real time, masculinity reduced to its collective and procedural form. Garland's screenplay for *28 Years Later* (2025, dir. Boyle) is built around a father's initiation of his son into killing; it contains an infected mother who delivers an uninfected child; and its prologue shows a boy whose vicar father welcomes the infected into his church as if they heralded the Second Coming. That boy grows into the leader of a cult whose followers surrender their names to his, the Jimmies in their identical tracksuits and wigs, developed further in *28 Years Later: The Bone Temple* (2026, dir. Nia DaCosta). Monoprosopy becomes onomastic: one name for many bodies, descended once again from a clerical father. The Jimmies' tracksuits and blond wigs were widely read as evoking Jimmy Savile, the BBC presenter exposed after his death in 2011 as a serial sexual abuser of children and adults over several decades, much of it committed on the premises of the BBC and of NHS hospitals; those institutions, and police who investigated allegations against him without bringing charges, failed to stop him during his lifetime (Gray and Watt 2013; Smith 2016). The allusion names the British case that most exactly matches the structure this

thesis reads in Cotson: one man's abuse sheltered by the institutions of a whole community.

1.9 Seven modes of motherless genesis

Read together, the corpus amounts to a typology of motherless genesis. In each case the attempt to generate without the mother yields either the monstrous or the same, and in each case a woman stands at the point where the system's reproduction would complete itself.

Work	Year	Mode of motherless genesis	What is reproduced	The woman's position
28 Days Later	2002	Viral replication	Rage	Claimed as the future's raw material
Never Let Me Go	2010	Cloning	Bodies for harvest	A clone among clones, seeking her original
Ex Machina	2014	*Technē*: the Pygmalion fantasy	The made woman	Manufactured; escapes her maker
Annihilation	2018	Refraction and mutation	Doubles	Guilty survivor; embraces the copy
Devs	2020	Computation	The dead daughter	Declines the predicted act
Men	2022	Agnatic birth	The husband and his claim	Interrogates; withholds
28 Years Later	2025	Onomastic cult	A name	An infected mother bears an uninfected child

The table makes the culmination visible. In every other work an external agent mediates the genesis: a virus, a laboratory, a machine, an alien zone, a cult. In *Men* the agent is removed. What reproduces itself is simply men, and what is reproduced is not a body for use, nor a fantasy woman, nor a resurrected child, but a man and a demand.

Chapter Two

The Font

Green Man, Wild Man, Sheela-na-gig and the Clerical Womb



The baptismal font in Cotson's church is the film's iconographic key. It sets a male emblem of vegetal regeneration and a female emblem of genital birth on either side of a basin in which the Church performs its own motherless rite of rebirth, and the finale's chain of births enacts, in flesh, what the font depicts in stone.

2.1 Description

At the pre-iconographic level the object is simple: a stone basin on a pedestal, carved on one face with a human head whose features sprout and disgorge foliage, and on another with a squatting naked female figure, her face mask-like, her hands holding open her genitals. Harper touches it; the camera lingers. At the iconographic level the motifs are identifiable at once: the foliate head that the twentieth century named the Green Man, and the Sheela-na-gig. At the iconological level the question is what their conjunction means on a *font*, the vessel of baptismal regeneration, and why a film about a woman's grief should stage its first theological encounter there.

The conjunction is itself a condensation. Medieval churches distributed such motifs across corbels, capitals and doorways rather than gathering them on a single basin. Kilpeck, in the same county as the fictional Cotson, carries on its corbel table the most celebrated Sheela-na-gig in England amid a bestiary of

grotesques. Garland's production design compresses a regional repertoire into one object, as a Warburgian atlas compresses centuries into a panel.

2.2 The Green Man and the invention of a pagan survival

The term "Green Man" was coined by Julia, Lady Raglan, in 1939, in an article linking the medieval foliate head to May Day figures such as Jack-in-the-Green and to a putative pre-Christian spirit of vegetation (Raglan 1939). Her synthesis rested on Frazer's *Golden Bough*, whose tree-spirits and dying-and-rising gods supplied an interpretive frame of irresistible elegance (Frazer 1906–15). Kathleen Basford read the same carvings darkly, as images of death, sin and the fallen soul, foliage marking mortality and lust rather than renewal (Basford 1978). William Anderson read them as a Jungian archetype of humanity's unity with the earth and helped launch their late-twentieth-century revival as icons of ecological spirituality (Anderson 1990).

Ronald Hutton dismantled the survivalist premise beneath all three. Foliate masks have classical antecedents in Roman decorative art; medieval carvers worked within Christian iconographic programmes; the Jack-in-the-Green emerged among London chimney sweeps in the eighteenth century; and the Green Man as pagan deity is in large part a modern construction (Hutton 1991, 1996; Judge 1979). Jonathan Z. Smith subjected Frazer's category of the dying-and-rising god to a comparable critique (Smith 1987). The film's Green Man therefore carries two afterlives at once: the medieval foliate head, poised between renewal and corruption, and the modern myth of the Green Man as an emblem of natural, regenerative masculinity. Garland exploits both. Naked, scratched and thorn-pierced, his figure begins as a wild man and ends as the foliate god of rebirth, and the rebirth he presides over is the reproduction of a husband. James is the film's dying-and-rising god: dead in the prologue, reborn at the close.

Frazer's opening image is equally pertinent. *The Golden Bough* begins in the grove of Nemi, where the priest of Diana, the King of the Wood, held office until slain by the man who would succeed him: a cyclical succession of men in a sacred grove, each the murderer and the replacement of the last. *Men* inverts Nemi. Its men succeed one another not by killing but by being born from one another, an apparently peaceful succession that transmits the wound in place of the sword.

The late-fourteenth-century *Sir Gawain and the Green Knight* supplies the Green figure's literary *locus classicus*. The Green Knight survives his own beheading, lifts his severed head and speaks; Gawain's fault is marked by a nick on the neck, a wound as the sign of a moral failure. At the moment of exposure

Gawain erupts into an antifeminist diatribe that catalogues Adam, Solomon, Samson and David as men undone by women. The green figure and the misogynist catalogue are co-present at the poem's climax: the man who has failed displaces the failure onto women. David Lowery's *The Green Knight* (2021), distributed by A24 a year before *Men*, completes a diptych in which the Green Man returns to the screen as an emblem of what outlasts masculine striving. Garland's version of the figure does not outlast masculinity; it begets it.

2.3 The wild man

Before the foliage, the naked man is a wodewose: the hairy wild man of medieval art, heraldry and romance, who lives in the forest beyond law, speech and society (Bernheimer 1952). A number of late-medieval East Anglian fonts station wodewoses around their bases as guardians of the sacrament, so that the wild man already stands, in English church furniture, at the threshold of baptism. Hayden White argued that the wild man is a projection by which civilisation defines itself through negation, and that modernity internalised the figure as the wild man within (White 1972). Montaigne had anticipated the point with a vegetal analogy: we call the peoples of the New World wild as we call wild the fruits that nature produces of herself, when it is the fruits we have altered by artifice that deserve the name (Montaigne 1580).

The analogy is precisely the film's, which moves from an apple eaten in a garden to a wild man in a field. The birth chain then stages White's thesis anatomically. The wild man is not the antithesis of the landlord, the vicar and the constable but their progenitor. Civility is born from wildness and carries its wound.

2.4 The Sheela-na-gig

Sheela-na-gigs are carvings of naked female figures displaying exaggerated vulvas, found on churches and castles in Ireland and Britain, with Romanesque antecedents in France and Spain; the name entered antiquarian literature in the nineteenth century, and its etymology remains disputed. Four interpretive traditions compete. Jørgen Andersen traced the figures to Continental Romanesque sculpture and read them as hags (Andersen 1977). Anthony Weir and James Jerman situated them within Romanesque programmes of sin, as warnings against *luxuria* (Weir and Jerman 1986). Eamonn Kelly emphasised their apotropaic function on Irish walls and gates (Kelly 1996). Barbara Freitag read

them as folk figures of birth and death, protective presences at the thresholds of life (Freitag 2004).

The apotropaic reading has a psychoanalytic and a mythological genealogy. In "Medusa's Head" Freud argued that the display of the genitals wards off evil, citing Rabelais's tale of the devil who flees at the sight of a woman's vulva (Freud 1922; Rabelais 1552, IV.47). The mythological archetype is Baubo, who, in the version preserved by Clement of Alexandria, lifts her robe before the grieving Demeter and makes the goddess laugh (Clement, *Protrepticus* II.20–21); in the Homeric *Hymn to Demeter* the same office falls to Iambe's jests. The Sheela belongs to a *Pathosformel* in which female obscenity breaks mourning. The film's heroine is in mourning. Chapter Seven returns to what breaks it.

Whatever their original function, Sheela-na-gigs stood at thresholds, above doorways, on gates, at the boundary of sacred and profane space. The vulva they display is a door. Tertullian's figure of woman as the devil's gateway, examined in the next chapter, is already carved into the church.

2.5 The font as the womb of the Church

Baptism is Christianity's second birth. In the Fourth Gospel Jesus tells Nicodemus that no one can see the kingdom of God except he be born again, of water and of the Spirit, and Nicodemus asks the question on which the whole of *Men* turns: "How can a man be born when he is old? can he enter the second time into his mother's womb, and be born?" (John 3:4, KJV). The Christian answer is the font, a second womb administered by the clergy, which renders the first womb soteriologically insufficient. Titus 3:5 names baptism the *lavacrum regenerationis*, the washing of regeneration.

Patristic theology made the identification explicit. Leo the Great, preaching at Christmas, declared that Christ placed in the font of baptism the origin he took in the Virgin's womb, and gave to the water what he gave to his mother: *dedit aquae quod dedit matri*. Cyprian had already formulated the institutional consequence: he cannot have God for his father who does not have the Church for his mother (*De unitate* 6). The mother is now an institution, and the institution is administered by fathers. The generative power of the maternal body is relocated to an instrument operated by celibate men; birth into life is subordinated to birth into salvation; the mother bears the child into death, under original sin, and the Church bears it into life.

This is the Christian form of what this thesis calls agnatic recursion, and the font of Cotson displays its terms with diagrammatic clarity: male vegetal

regeneration on one face, female genital birth on another, and between them the clerical basin that claims to supersede both. It is at this font that Harper meets the vicar, whose theology will hold her responsible for a man's death. The finale enacts the font. Each Kinnear body opens; each delivered man emerges slick with fluid, as from immersion; the line runs from the Green Man through the vicar to the husband. It is baptism carried to its literal conclusion, a rebirth in which no woman participates. Yet the Sheela is not abolished. The openings through which the men deliver one another appear at a different site on each body; the vulva migrates from the woman on the font to the men in the house. The Sheela is not superseded but appropriated.

2.6 The Welsh matrix: Math, Gwydion and Blodeuwedd

Herefordshire's position on the Welsh March licenses a further analogue. The Fourth Branch of the *Mabinogi*, preserved in the White Book of Rhydderch and the Red Book of Hergest, is the most concentrated medieval British meditation on male usurpations of birth, and it anticipates the finale with uncanny precision.

Gilfaethwy, abetted by his brother Gwydion, rapes Goewin, the maiden in whose lap King Math must rest his feet. Math punishes the brothers by transforming them for three successive years into mated pairs of animals, deer, then swine, then wolves, each brother in turn taking the female part and bearing young to the other; the offspring are restored to human form and named. Rape is answered by enforced male gestation. The medieval text thus contains the exact juridical form that *Men* will make ambiguous: men who have raped a woman are compelled to bear.

The Branch continues in the same register. When Arianrhod steps over Math's wand, a test of virginity, she drops a child and "a small thing" which Gwydion snatches and hides in a chest, where it grows into the boy Lleu; Gwydion becomes, in effect, a male womb and a male mother. When Arianrhod curses Lleu never to have a wife of the race now on earth, Math and Gwydion conjure one from the flowers of oak, broom and meadowsweet: Blodeuwedd, the woman of flowers, made by men for a man's use. She loves another, conspires in Lleu's wounding, and is punished by transformation into an owl, shunned by all birds. Blodeuwedd is the Green Man's feminine counterpart and his inversion: where his foliage figures male self-renewal, hers figures female manufacture for male use and the punishment of female desire.

Alan Garner's *The Owl Service* (1967) brought the myth into the modern British landscape. Three adolescents in a Welsh valley are compelled to re-enact the

Blodeuwedd triangle, which has recurred through the valley's generations; the cycle breaks only when the woman is seen as flowers rather than owls, when the male imagination ceases to convert her into a figure of predatory guilt. Garner's novel is the closest literary precedent for the spatial logic of *Men*: a landscape that compels the repetition of a gendered myth across generations, and a woman whose release depends on whether she is permitted to be something other than the culprit.

The font and its analogues together compose the archive on which the finale draws: male regeneration without women (the Green Man, Nemi, baptism, Math's punishment, Gwydion's chest); female birth reduced to an apotropaic emblem or a moralised warning (the Sheela-na-gig); and women manufactured or blamed (Pandora, Blodeuwedd, Gawain's catalogue). The next chapter follows the blame to its theological source.

Chapter Three

The Fall Redistributed

Eden, Tertullian, Augustine and the Patristic Economy of Blame



Men rewrites the Fall in its opening minutes: a man falls, a woman eats an apple, and the village spends the rest of the film assigning her the guilt for both. The theological sources of that assignment, from Genesis through Tertullian and Augustine to the Athenian myths of autochthony, explain why the finale must take the form of male birth.

3.1 The apple and the joke

Shortly after her arrival Harper picks an apple from the tree in the manor's garden and bites it; Geoffrey reproves her, then withdraws the reproof as a joke. Genesis does not name the fruit (Gen. 2:17; 3:6). The apple's dominance in Western iconography owes much to the Latin homonymy of *malum*, evil, and *mālum*, apple, which allowed the tree of the knowledge of good and evil, *lignum scientiae boni et mali*, to bear the fruit of its own name. Geoffrey's joke is a catechesis: within minutes of her arrival the woman is positioned as Eve and her appetite as transgression.

The joke's withdrawal is essential to its function. Freud showed that the tendentious joke permits the expression of an aggression that would otherwise be censored, and that its structure is triangular: the teller, the object and the third party who laughs (Freud 1905). Geoffrey's joke has no third within the scene; the third is the spectator, and the film declines to laugh. "Only joking" is the deniable

form of interpellation. It names Harper as Eve and leaves her no position from which to object without becoming what Sara Ahmed calls the feminist killjoy, the woman whose refusal to laugh is itself treated as the offence (Ahmed 2010).

3.2 The falling man

The prologue reverses the sex of the Fall while preserving its distribution of guilt. It is the man who falls, past the window, his eyes meeting Harper's in a suspended instant of reciprocal looking; he lands on the railings, partially impaled, his forearm ruptured. The tableau has the structure of a Passion: the woman at the window as witness to a male death, a *mater dolorosa* of a sacrifice for which she will be held responsible. The Easter liturgy calls Adam's sin the *felix culpa*, the happy fault that occasioned redemption. James's fall occasions no redemption. It occasions a debt.

The ambiguity of the fall, an apparent suicide that may equally have been an accident in an attempt to re-enter the flat, is itself theologically structured. If it was suicide, James has made his death an accusation. If it was accident, his death results from his refusal to accept exclusion, for he was trying to get back in. Either way, the woman's act, the announced divorce and the locked door, is placed at the origin of his death. Locking the door is the original sin of the film's moral economy, and it will be answered by a night of men forcing doors.

3.3 Tertullian: the devil's gateway

The source of that economy can be located with precision. In *De cultu feminarum* (c. 200) Tertullian addresses every woman as Eve:

> *Tu es diaboli ianua; tu es arboris illius resignatrix; tu es divinae legis prima desertrix; tu es quae eum suasisti quem diabolus aggredi non valuit; tu imaginem dei, hominem, tam facile elisisti; propter tuum meritum, id est mortem, etiam filius dei mori habuit.* (I.1.2)

You are the devil's gateway; you are the unsealer of that tree; you are the first deserter of the divine law; you persuaded him whom the devil was not strong enough to attack; you so easily destroyed God's image, man; because of your desert, that is, death, even the Son of God had to die.

Four features of the passage govern the film. The first is *ianua*: woman as door, the threshold through which evil enters. *Men* is a sustained meditation on doors: the locked door of the London flat; the manor's front door left ajar; the letterbox through which a hand and then an arm are thrust; the tunnel's mouth; the

window past which James falls; and, at the climax, the bodily openings through which men deliver men. The second is *resignatrix*, she who breaks the seal. Harper's divorce unseals a sacrament.

The third is the causal chain from a woman's desert to a man's death, and beyond it to the death of God: Tertullian's woman is responsible not only for Adam's mortality but for the Crucifixion. The vicar's suggestion that Harper bears responsibility for James's death is Tertullianic down to its grammar, for the woman's act is the *meritum* whose wages are the man's death. The fourth is *imaginem dei*, *hominem*: man as the image of God, the image that woman destroyed. In *Men* that image proliferates. The face Tertullian accused woman of effacing is the face the film multiplies.

The film's decisive operation is to relocate the *ianua*. In the night sequence it is the men who press at the doors. The arm that comes through the letterbox is a male arm, and in the finale the men's bodies themselves become gateways, opening to deliver the next man. The gateway is male. This relocation is what the thesis names the *ianua virorum*: the male body as the door through which violence passes from one generation to the next.

3.4 Traducianism: the soul as a vine-shoot

Tertullian is also the source of the film's theory of descent. In *De anima* (c. 210) he argued that the soul is corporeal and transmitted with the seed in the act of generation, every soul derived from Adam's as a shoot from a vine; hence the name later given to the doctrine, traducianism, from *tradux*. The metaphor is horticultural. A *tradux* is a vine-branch trained along the ground or layered into the soil so that it roots while still attached to the parent and becomes a new plant. Layering is vegetative propagation: asexual and clonal, the new plant identical to the old.

Traducianism therefore theologises the transmission of the soul, and with it of sin, as clonal propagation from a single male origin. The finale of *Men* is traducianism made visible. Each man roots from the one before, still attached, identical in face, the line descending from a foliate progenitor. The Green Man is a vine, and the men of Cotson propagate *per traducem*.

Augustine never resolved the choice between traducianism and creationism, the doctrine that God creates each soul anew. His letter to Jerome confesses the difficulty: if souls are newly created, how is Adam's sin transmitted (Augustine, *Ep.* 166)? *Men* answers the question in images. The masculinity it depicts is traducian, and what it transmits is the wound.

3.5 Augustine: all were in that one man

Augustine's doctrine of original sin, as it was received in the Latin West, rests in part on a translation. The Latin of Romans 5:12 reads that death passed to all men *in quo omnes peccaverunt*, "in whom all sinned", where the Greek *eph' hō* is more naturally construed as "because" or "inasmuch as" all sinned. Augustine built on the Latin: *omnes enim fuimus in illo uno*, "for we were all in that one man" (*City of God* XIII.14), present in his seminal nature before we were individually formed. Humanity is a single man folded within Adam, unfolding through generation.

Early modern embryology gave the theological idea an anatomical form. The doctrine of preformation, in its *emboîtement* or encasement variant associated with Swammerdam and Malebranche, held that every organism contained, nested within it in miniature, all the generations that would descend from it; Nicolaas Hartsoeker's drawing of 1694, a homunculus curled in the head of a spermatozoon, became the emblem of the spermist version. Each man contains all the men to come. The finale of *Men* is *emboîtement* rendered as body horror: each man opens to disclose the next, a nesting of identical faces. Critics reached for the image of the Russian doll, and the image is exact in a way they did not remark. The matryoshka is a doll of the mother, here pressed into the service of the sons.

Augustine also imagined how procreation would have proceeded in Eden had there been no Fall. The generative organs would have moved at the command of the will, as hands and feet do, without lust; the man would have sown his seed as a farmer sows a field (*City of God* XIV.23–24). The penalty of the Fall is precisely the rebellion of the flesh against the will, the involuntary motion of the sexual body. In *Men* the Augustinian fantasy of sovereign male generation returns as its opposite. The births are convulsive, involuntary and agonised; the men do not will them; their flesh rebels. And the curse they suffer is not Adam's but Eve's: "in sorrow thou shalt bring forth children" (Gen. 3:16, KJV). The finale transfers the curse of Eve to the sons of Adam.

3.6 The embryology of the father: Aeschylus, Aristotle, Athens

The patristic economy has a pagan prehistory. In Aeschylus's *Eumenides* (458 BCE), Apollo defends the matricide Orestes by arguing that the mother is not the parent of the child but only the nurse of the newly sown seed; the true parent is the one who mounts, and the proof is Athena herself, born of Zeus without a mother (*Eum.* 658–666). Athena casts her vote for Orestes, declaring that she favours the male in all things, for no mother bore her. The foundation myth of the

Athenian court on the Areopagus is thus the acquittal of a matricide on the ground that mothers do not generate.

Aristotle's *Generation of Animals* systematised the doctrine. The male contributes form and the principle of motion, the female only matter, and the female is, as it were, a deformed or mutilated male (GA II.3, 737a27–28). In *Men* the men become female in precisely Aristotle's sense, by becoming mutilated. The split arm and the broken ankle precede the births. The wound is the route of feminisation and of parturition.

Nicole Loraux showed that the Athenian myths of autochthony, in which citizens are born from the earth as Erichthonius was born from the soil on which Hephaestus's seed fell, grounded a civic identity from which women were structurally excluded: the citizen is born of the land rather than of woman, while women descend from Pandora as a separate "race of women" (Loraux 1981; Hesiod, *Theogony* 590–591). The polis is a brotherhood of men born of the soil. Cotson is an autochthonous polis: its landlord, priest, constable and publican spring from the Green Man, who is the soil personified.

Claude Lévi-Strauss read the Oedipus myth as a device for mediating a contradiction between the belief that humans are autochthonous, born from one, and the knowledge that they are born from the union of man and woman, born from two (Lévi-Strauss 1955). *Men* stages the contradiction without mediating it. The men are born from one; the last of them demands two. The chain of autochthonous births terminates in a request that only another can satisfy, and the request reveals that the fantasy of self-generation has not abolished its dependence upon the woman. It has displaced that dependence from the womb to the heart.

3.7 The vicar: Nietzsche's ascetic priest

The vicar is the film's theologian, and his operation can be specified exactly. Nietzsche's ascetic priest manages suffering by changing the direction of ressentiment. The sufferer reasons that someone must be to blame for his pain; the priest agrees, and tells him that he himself is that someone (*Genealogy* III.15). The vicar performs this operation on Harper. Her suffering, the violence she endured and the death she witnessed, is converted into guilt: she did not allow James to apologise. The economy of repentance is turned against the victim, for whom forgiveness becomes an obligation and the abuser's apology a right that she has wrongfully obstructed.

The operation has an institutional form in the long pastoral tradition of counselling abused wives to forgive, submit and preserve the marriage, criticised from within the churches by Marie Fortune and others (Fortune 1987). It has a psychological form in what Jennifer Freyd named DARVO, the abuser's characteristic sequence of denial, attack and the reversal of victim and offender (Freyd 1997). It has a moral-philosophical form in what Kate Manne calls himpathy, the excess of sympathy for male perpetrators that installs their suffering at the moral centre of the scene (Manne 2017). James's threat to kill himself should she divorce him belongs to the repertoire Evan Stark theorised as coercive control (Stark 2007), an offence in English law since the Serious Crime Act 2015 (s. 76). The vicar's theology is the clerical sanctification of that control after the controller's death.

3.8 Leda and the swan

The vicar's attempted rape of Harper is framed by an allusion to W. B. Yeats's sonnet "Leda and the Swan" (1924), in which he casts himself as the swan. The poem renders the rape of Leda by Zeus as an act whose consequences are history itself:

> A shudder in the loins engenders there
> The broken wall, the burning roof and tower
> And Agamemnon dead.

In Yeats's *A Vision* (1925; revised 1937), Leda's rape is an annunciation that inaugurates the classical era, as the Annunciation to Mary inaugurates the Christian; history turns in gyres of two thousand years, each begun by a god's descent upon a woman. The vicar's citation sacralises rape as the founding of history, and it does so in the voice of the clergy.

Three further resonances bind the poem to the film. Zeus is the patrogenetic god *par excellence*, who bears Athena from his head and Dionysus from his thigh: the swan is the god who does not need a mother. The poem's closing question, whether Leda put on the god's knowledge with his power before "the indifferent beak could let her drop", asks whether the violated woman acquires what violated her; Harper ends the film in possession of knowledge without power, and declines the only power she is offered, the power to absolve. Finally, in Yeats the god lets the woman drop; in *Men* the man falls, and the woman is told that she let him. Leda is the mother of Helen, whose palinode exonerated her by means of a double

(§1.6). The vicar's citation summons the very lineage by which Harper will be acquitted.

3.9 One substance, many persons

The same Tertullian who called woman the devil's gateway gave Latin theology the word *trinitas* and the grammar of one *substantia* in three *personae* (*Adversus Praxean*, c. 213). *Persona* is the theatrical mask. The Nicene Creed confesses the Son begotten of the Father before all ages and of one substance with him, *homoousios*: an eternal generation of male from male at the summit of being, the archetype of agnatic recursion. The third person's grammatical gender wanders across the sacred languages, feminine in Hebrew *ruach*, neuter in Greek *pneuma*, masculine in Latin *spiritus*, as though the feminine had been present at the origin and progressively neutralised. Mary Daly compressed the consequence into an aphorism: if God is male, then the male is God (Daly 1973).

Men applies the Nicene grammar to an English village. One substance, Kinnear's face, appears in many *personae*: landlord, priest, constable, publican, drinker, boy and wild man. One of them, the boy, is literally masked. The film's monoprosopy is consubstantiality made visible, and it exposes what the doctrine concealed beneath its majesty: that a generation of male from male requires no woman, and that a theology which can imagine such a generation as the highest form of being will find woman, at best, superfluous, and at worst, the gateway through which death came in. The finale grants the theology its deepest wish, and the wish, granted, is a horror.

Chapter Four

The Monstrous-Masculine

Psychoanalysis, Abjection and the Consummation of Womb Envy



The finale's births fulfil the oldest masculine fantasy psychoanalysis has named, envy of the womb, by means of the deepest masculine terror it has named, the liquefaction of the bounded male body. The film's horror lies in the identity of the two.

4.1 The uncanny and the double

Freud defined the uncanny as the return of something once familiar, *heimlich*, that has been repressed (Freud 1919). Following Otto Rank, he traced the double from its origin as an insurance against destruction, the immortal soul being the first double of the body, to its later role as the harbinger of death once that primitive narcissism has been surmounted (Rank 1914). Among uncanny phenomena Freud lists the constant recurrence of the same thing: the same features, the same character traits, the same vicissitudes, the same crimes and even the same names through several consecutive generations. It is an exact description of agnatic recursion, written a century before the film.

Freud adds that men often find the female genitals uncanny because they are the entrance to the former home, the *Heim*, of all human beings. *Men* operates by transposing this observation. Its house, an old manor and so a *Heim* in the most literal sense, is besieged by men who want in: through the door, the window, the letterbox. Their desire is, in Freud's terms, the desire to return to the former

home. They cannot enter; instead they become it. The finale places the entrance to the former home on the male body. The uncanny migrates from the female to the male genitals, as the Sheela-na-gig migrates from the font to the men.

4.2 *Totem and Taboo*: stronger dead than alive

In Freud's myth of the primal horde, the brothers kill the father who monopolised the women; guilt follows; and the dead father becomes stronger than the living one had been, his prohibitions reinstated by the sons as law, religion and morality (Freud 1913). The institutions are the dead father's afterlife. *Men* realises the myth with precision. James dead is stronger than James alive. He is diffused through the village's institutions, property in the landlord, religion in the vicar, law in the constable, commerce and community in the publican and his pub, the next generation in the boy, nature in the wild man, and he returns from them at the end of the chain.

The film nevertheless reverses Freud's distribution of guilt. In *Totem and Taboo* the sons bear the guilt of the parricide, and that guilt is the cement of their society. In *Men* the guilt is exported to a woman who killed no one. The totemic economy is masculinised at the point of power and feminised at the point of guilt. The brothers keep the father's authority and send his ghost's bill to his widow.

4.3 Abjection and the monstrous-feminine reversed

Julia Kristeva defined the abject as what disturbs identity, system and order, what does not respect borders, positions and rules: the corpse at its limit, bodily fluids, and, at the origin of subjectivity, the maternal body from which the infant must separate in order to become a subject at all (Kristeva 1980). Barbara Creed showed that the horror film constructs this abject reproductive body as the monstrous-feminine, in its guises as archaic mother, monstrous womb, witch, vampire, possessed body and castrating woman, through films such as *The Exorcist* (1973), *Carrie* (1976), *Alien* (1979) and *The Brood* (1979) (Creed 1993).

Men transfers the abject to the male reproductive body, which leaks, splits, labours and delivers, slick with fluid: the monstrous-masculine. Creed had begun the transfer herself. In *Phallic Panic* (2005) she argued that the male monster is persistently feminised, bleeding, penetrable or born without a mother, and that horror's primal uncanny lies in the collapse of the boundaries of the male body. *Men* is among the genre's most systematic completions of that argument.

The comparative field is instructive. In *Alien*, a creature forces an embryo into a crewman, Kane, through his mouth, and the chestburster later erupts from his

body in what remains cinema's most notorious male birth; its screenwriter Dan O'Bannon said he set out to attack the men in the audience with images of oral rape and male birth. In *The Brood*, a woman's rage is externalised as children born from a womb outside her body, who kill her mother, her father and her daughter's teacher. Cronenberg's *Crimes of the Future*, released within weeks of *Men* in 2022, imagines a male body that grows new organs for display, surgery become the new sex. *Dead Ringers* (1988) doubles a single actor as twin gynaecologists who deceive women about which brother they are sleeping with, and one of whom, in collapse, injures a patient in surgery with instruments designed for "mutant women". *Men* multiplies that doubling sevenfold and turns its gynaecology upon men.

4.4 Womb envy

Karen Horney answered Freud's theory of penis envy with its inverse. Boys, she argued, envy pregnancy, childbirth and motherhood, and the formidable masculine drive toward creative work in every field may be an over-compensation for men's small part in the creation of living beings (Horney 1926). Bruno Bettelheim generalised the thesis anthropologically. Male initiation rites across many cultures, including subincision, the longitudinal incision of the underside of the penis, express envy of female reproductive power: the wound as symbolic vulva, its bleeding as symbolic menstruation (Bettelheim 1954). The couvade, documented by Edward Tylor, in which fathers ritually imitate labour, belongs to the same complex (Tylor 1865). Melanie Klein defined envy as the impulse to spoil the good object one cannot possess, and contrasted it with gratitude (Klein 1957).

Read through Bettelheim, the split arm is a subincision: a longitudinal wound that opens the limb into a vulvar form. Its sequence is legible as a single sentence. The male arm thrust through the letterbox is an intrusion; the woman's blade is a cut; the longitudinal split is an opening; and within the hour come the births. Intrusion becomes castration; castration becomes not lack but orifice; orifice becomes birth canal. The symbolic wound literally produces a womb. And the wound is transmitted, from the naked man to the boy to the vicar, as James's own injuries, the ruptured arm and the broken ankle, pass to the naked man.

In Klein's terms, James's blow to Harper's face when she proposes to leave is envy's attack upon a good object that will no longer be possessed. His final demand for love is envy's petition to the object it has spoiled. Gratitude, the Kleinian counter-term, is exactly what the film's men never feel: they experience what they receive as owed.

4.5 Theweleit: the armoured body and its liquefaction

Klaus Theweleit's study of the writings of the Freikorps showed the soldier male constructing his body as armour against fluidity in every form: floods, mire, the "red flood" of revolution, and female sexuality figured as liquid dissolution (Theweleit 1977–78). His ego is a dam and his terror is liquefaction. He also fantasises a second birth within the male collective of the drill-ground and the troop, a body remade without the mother.

The finale of *Men* fulfils the fantasy by means of the terror. The armour cracks; the man becomes fluid; and from the fluid comes the next man. Fantasy and terror are revealed to be one structure. This is the dialectic on which the film's climax turns: the wish to be born of men, granted, takes the form of exactly what the wish was erected to defend against. Theweleit allows the reading to be historicised as well as psychoanalysed, because the armoured body is not a timeless male essence but a formation with a history, produced by institutions, the very institutions whose faces the film distributes across Kinnear.

4.6 Lacan: the masculine universal and its exception

Lacan's formulas of sexuation define the masculine position by a universal, all men are subject to the phallic function, grounded on an exception, there exists at least one who is not: the primal father of *Totem and Taboo*. The feminine position is defined by the not-all, woman is not wholly subject to that function, and by the absence of any exception; hence Lacan's notorious formula that Woman does not exist, there being no universal of Woman, only women one by one (Lacan 1972–73).

Men visualises the masculine side with diagrammatic exactness. Monoprosopy is the universal quantifier made visible: all men, one face. The exception is the naked man, outside law, speech and clothing, the primal father before the law, and he stands at the head of the birth chain: from the exception, the universal is born. Harper occupies the not-all. She is singular and untotalisable, she has a face of her own, and the only other women in the film, Riley and the police officer, are equally singular. In the regime the film depicts, Man exists, and woman exists only one at a time.

The formula clarifies a contemporary discourse. The slogan "not all men", the defensive reply to generalisations about male violence, attempts to claim the place of the exception: not me. In Lacan's logic, however, the claim to be the exception is precisely what founds the universal, for the "all" is constituted by the "at least one who is not". Each man's claim to be the exception reproduces the

structure of the set. The film literalises the paradox. Each Kinnear figure is a distinct type, and each could plausibly claim exemption: the awkward but kindly landlord, the pastoral vicar, the dutiful constable. Each wears the same face. The film's form answers "not all men" not by asserting that all men are violent, an empirical claim it never makes, but by showing that the category "all men" is produced by the serial claim to be the exception.

A second Lacanian figure governs the final scene. In "The Subversion of the Subject and the Dialectic of Desire" (1960), Lacan's graph of desire inscribes the question *Che vuoi*?, What do you want?, which the subject addresses to the enigmatic desire of the Other. The phrase comes from Jacques Cazotte's *Le Diable amoureux* (1772), in which a devil conjured by the young Alvare appears asking *Che vuoi*? and then assumes the form of a woman, Biondetta, who professes her love and demands his. Harper's question to James on the sofa is the *Che vuoi*?, and his answer reverses Cazotte. The devil who demands love has become a man.

4.7 Ovid: Tiresias, Echo and Narcissus

The third book of Ovid's *Metamorphoses* contains, in sequence, the film's three mythic coordinates. Tiresias, who lived seven years as a woman, is asked by Jupiter and Juno to adjudicate whether men or women take greater pleasure in love; he answers that women do, and is blinded by Juno and granted prophecy by Jupiter. His first prophecy concerns Narcissus: asked whether the boy will live to old age, he replies *si se non noverit*, if he does not come to know himself (III.348). Echo, cursed by Juno to repeat only the last words of others, loves Narcissus and is rejected; Narcissus falls in love with his reflection, recognises it, *iste ego sum*, I am he (III.463), and dies; Echo wastes to voice and bone.

The men of Cotson live under Tiresias's condition: they survive because they never know themselves. No one in the film remarks the shared face, and no Kinnear figure confronts his likeness in another and says *iste ego sum*. Self-recognition would end the replication; it is the one event the system cannot survive. Harper in the tunnel is Echo, but an Echo who repeats her own voice rather than the last words of others, and whose echo the score harmonises into a chord. The figure that screams and runs at her from the tunnel's far end is the moment Narcissus breaks in upon Echo: the male image interrupting the female voice's relation to itself. Chapter Seven develops this into the first of the film's counter-generations.

4.8 Dream, delusion and the trap of the subjective reading

A persistent critical reading holds that the men's resemblance is Harper's projection, a symptom of trauma, and that the film depicts not men but one woman's fear of them. The film permits the reading and then turns it against its holder. The resemblance is visible to the spectator and never remarked by Harper; the condensation addresses us. Clinical psychiatry names the conviction that different people are a single persecutor in disguise the Fregoli delusion, and Charlie Kaufman and Duke Johnson's *Anomalisa* (2015) named its hotel after it. *Men* places the spectator in the Fregoli position and asks whether the perception of sameness is a pathology, a political insight, or both.

The purely subjective reading answers too quickly, and in answering it repeats the vicar. It converts a structural observation into a symptom and relocates the problem from the men to the woman's perception of them: DARVO at the level of hermeneutics. Freud did not treat condensation as falsification. The collective figure of the dream tells the truth about an element the dream-thoughts share. Monoprosopy is a truth about the men told in the language of dreams, namely what they have in common, and the refusal to adjudicate between the real and the projected is not a puzzle left for the critic to solve but a trap laid for the critic who would solve it by blaming the dreamer.

Chapter Five

Feminist Genealogies

Comparative Readings



Men is best understood not as a feminist film, in the sense of a film that argues a feminist thesis, but as a film that stages in images a sequence of problems feminist thought had already formulated in concepts. The comparison sharpens both: it shows what the film borrows, what it adds, and where it falls short.

5.1 Beauvoir: the Subject, the Other and the man born of men

Beauvoir's *The Second Sex* (1949) established that man is the Subject, the Absolute, and woman the Other, defined in relation to him; the masculine is at once positive and neutral. Its second volume opens with the most quoted sentence of twentieth-century feminism: one is not born, but rather becomes, a woman. *Men* stages the masculine corollary, and stages it as farce and horror at once. One is not born a man; one becomes a man, and the film shows the becoming as a literal birth through men. The chain of births materialises the social construction of masculinity: it is produced by fathers, priests, constables, landlords and publicans, by men acting through institutions.

Yet the chain renders the social as if it were biological, the construction as gestation. This is Barthes's definition of myth, the transformation of history into nature (Barthes 1957). The finale is a myth in Barthes's sense and simultaneously its exposure, for the process is far too grotesque to pass as nature. The film

naturalises masculinity's social reproduction so excessively that the naturalisation becomes visible as a fabrication. Beauvoir's distinction between immanence, the repetitive maintenance of life to which women were confined, and transcendence, the project-making freedom reserved to men, is likewise reversed. In Cotson repetition is the men's condition. Only Harper transcends, surviving the night into a morning in which she is no longer alone.

Catharine MacKinnon compressed the asymmetry Beauvoir described into a sentence whose grammar is its argument: "Man fucks woman; subject verb object" (MacKinnon 1989). The film's title keeps the subject and suspends the rest. In *Men* the verb migrates from sex into the night's intrusions and finally into the births, and the object withdraws, for Harper declines to complete the sentence. Andrea Dworkin described the woman's body under male supremacy as territory entered and occupied, its boundary not hers to keep (Dworkin 1987). The siege of the manor literalises that figure: the house is the boundary the men press against, and the letterbox is its breach. The finale then inverts Dworkin's terms, for it is the male bodies that open from within, occupied by the men they bear.

5.2 Woolf: the looking-glass and the procession

In *A Room of One's Own* (1929) Woolf observed that women have served for centuries as looking-glasses with the power of reflecting the figure of man at twice its natural size, and that when a woman begins to tell the truth the figure in the glass shrinks. The final demand of *Men* is a demand for the looking-glass. To ask for Harper's love is to ask that she resume the office of reflecting James at twice his natural size. Her withholding is the shrinking.

Three Guineas (1938) supplies the film's costume design avant la lettre. Woolf reproduced photographs of men in their professional regalia, a general, heralds, a university procession, a judge, an archbishop, and argued that the tyranny of the patriarchal home and the tyranny of the fascist state are of one substance. Kinnear's wardrobe animates Woolf's plates: one man in the uniforms of property, church and law. Woolf's insight that the costumes conceal a single substance, the same men moved by the same desires beneath different robes, is the formal premise of *Men*.

5.3 Irigaray and Cixous: the economy of the same and the laugh of the Medusa

Luce Irigaray read Western philosophy as a specular economy in which woman serves as the mirror of masculine self-reflection, a "logic of the same" in which

sexual difference is reduced to a variation of the masculine (Irigaray 1974). In "Women on the Market" she named the social order *hom(m)o-sexual*: an economy of exchanges among men in which women circulate as commodities (Irigaray 1977). Against the specular she set the "two lips", a figure of female sexuality as plural and self-touching, a relation to oneself that requires no mirror. The finale of *Men* is the hom(m)o-sexual economy perfected: men exchanging not women but themselves, reproducing without the commodity. Yet the economy still requires the mirror, for its last product is a demand for love. The two lips will return in Chapter Seven as the model of Harper's echo.

Irigaray's reading of Hegel's Antigone took its title from Hegel's remark that womankind is the everlasting irony in the life of the community (Hegel 1807, ¶475; Irigaray 1974). Harper is the irony of Cotson: the one inhabitant who does not share its face. Hélène Cixous, answering Freud's petrifying Medusa, insisted that one need only look at the Medusa straight on to see her, and that she is not deadly but beautiful and laughing (Cixous 1975). Harper looks straight on. She looks at James as he falls, at the naked man in the field, at the births, and she is not turned to stone. Her final smile is the laugh of the Medusa. Cixous's catalogue of hierarchical binaries in "Sorties", activity and passivity, culture and nature, father and mother, illuminates the font's opposition of Green Man and Sheela-na-gig, and the film's twist upon it: in Cotson the men occupy both terms of every binary, wild man and vicar, nature and culture, leaving woman no term at all except the one she makes by leaving.

5.4 Sedgwick, Rubin and Girard: homosociality, exchange and the monstrous double

Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick's *Between Men* (1985) described a continuum of male homosocial desire and, after René Girard's triangular desire (Girard 1961), the erotic triangle in which men's bonds with one another are routed through a woman. The pub, the church and the constabulary of Cotson are homosocial institutions in this sense. Gayle Rubin's "The Traffic in Women" (1975), reading Lévi-Strauss's *Elementary Structures of Kinship* (1949), identified kinship as an exchange of women between men and named the sex/gender system that results. *Men* pushes Rubin's analysis to its limit. Kinship no longer requires the exchange; the men exchange themselves. Kinship becomes agnatic recursion.

Girard's *Violence and the Sacred* (1972) supplies the mechanism. Mimetic rivalry escalates into a crisis of undifferentiation in which antagonists become identical, monstrous doubles, and the community restores order through unanimous

violence against a scapegoat, typically a marginal figure, a stranger or an outsider. The men of Cotson are monstrous doubles in Girard's precise sense; the village is in a sacrificial crisis of undifferentiation; and Harper, stranger, woman and outsider, is the victim upon whom its violence converges. The vicar's accusation is the scapegoat's indictment in its classic form. But Girard's mechanism requires the victim's death, and the scapegoat of *Men* survives. That survival is the film's decisive departure from the sacrificial order.

5.5 Rich, Firestone and Atwood: of woman born

Adrienne Rich opened *Of Woman Born* (1976) with an axiom, that all human life on the planet is born of woman, and distinguished motherhood as experience from motherhood as an institution under patriarchal control. Her title alludes to *Macbeth*, whose tyrant is promised that "none of woman born / Shall harm Macbeth" and is undone by Macduff, "from his mother's womb / Untimely ripped". The men of Cotson are, literally, none of woman born, and they are the tyrants. The finale violates Rich's axiom, and the violation is the horror.

Shulamith Firestone located the root of women's oppression in reproductive biology and demanded women's liberation from it through artificial reproduction and the diffusion of childrearing (Firestone 1970). *Men* realises her programme in nightmare form. Reproduction is lifted from women's bodies, and transferred to men, who use it only to reproduce themselves. The lesson is not Firestone's error but her premise's condition: liberation from reproduction does not liberate if reproduction becomes an instrument of masculine self-perpetuation. The question was never technology but who reproduces what. Margaret Atwood's *The Handmaid's Tale* (1985) imagined a theocracy that appropriates women's reproductive capacity through ritual, scripture and surveillance. *Men* imagines Gilead's endgame: if women's reproduction is to be governed by men, its logical terminus is reproduction by men.

5.6 The Female Gothic

Ellen Moers named the Female Gothic, the Gothic written by women in which a persecuted heroine moves through enclosed and menacing spaces (Moers 1976); its prototype is Ann Radcliffe's *The Mysteries of Udolpho* (1794), whose supernatural terrors are finally explained away. *Men* belongs to the tradition and refuses its resolution: nothing is explained.

Charlotte Perkins Gilman's "The Yellow Wallpaper" (1892) is its closest ancestor. A woman is taken to a rented country house for a rest cure by a

physician husband who dismisses her perceptions; she sees in the wallpaper's pattern a woman, then many women, creeping behind the bars. Harper chooses her own rest cure in a rented country house; her perceptions are dismissed by the constable and reinterpreted by the vicar; and she sees not women multiplying in a pattern but men. Gilman's narrator ends by becoming the woman in the wallpaper, creeping over her fainted husband. Harper ends neither mad nor merged, but intact. Daphne du Maurier's *Rebecca* (1938) reverses the sexes of the film's haunting: there the dead wife possesses the house and the living spouse; here the dead husband does. Sandra Gilbert and Susan Gubar read the madwoman in the attic as the female author's double (Gilbert and Gubar 1979); in *Men* the madness is distributed across the men and never concentrated in the woman.

Angela Carter supplies two decisive intertexts. In "The Bloody Chamber" (1979), her Bluebeard, the Marquis, who has murdered his previous wives, is about to behead his new bride when she is saved not by a brother but by her mother, who gallops to the castle and shoots him: female rescue across generations, of which Riley's dawn arrival is a muted echo, too late to rescue and in time to witness. In *The Passion of New Eve* (1977), an Englishman who has abused his lover, and abandoned her after an abortion he pressed on her left her sterile, is captured by a matriarchal surgeon-goddess and surgically transformed into a woman against his will, in what the novel frames as both a mythic project and a retribution; she intends to impregnate the new Eve with his own stored seed, punishment by imposed womanhood as in Math's judgement, and reproduction as a closed loop; and Tristessa, Hollywood's supreme image of suffering femininity, is revealed to be a man. The boy's mask of a platinum-blonde screen siren is Tristessa in miniature: cinema's femininity worn by a male body. Joan Riviere had described womanliness as a masquerade worn to avert male retribution (Riviere 1929). The boy inverts her: his masquerade of femininity is worn to deliver male aggression, for from behind the mask he calls her a "stupid bitch".

5.7 Feminist film theory and the comparative screen

Laura Mulvey argued that classical cinema organises looking around a male gaze, with woman coded for "to-be-looked-at-ness", and that the male figure cannot bear the burden of sexual objectification (Mulvey 1975). *Men* compels the male body into the position of spectacle without eroticising it. The naked man is first seen in Harper's photograph: the woman holds the camera. Yet the gaze inside

the photograph is his, for he is watching her, and the film's opening already establishes the returned look, James's eyes meeting hers as he falls.

Carol Clover's *Men, Women, and Chain Saws* (1992), whose title Garland's own seems to abbreviate, identified the Final Girl: watchful, boyish, surviving by appropriating the killer's phallic violence, and offered to a largely male audience as a figure of cross-gender identification. Harper is not a Final Girl. She wounds in self-defence, but the finale is not a battle she wins; it is an ordeal she endures, and she ends not with the weapon raised but with an axe held and, so far as we see, unused. Clover's account of the rape-revenge film throws the refusal into relief. *Men* is a rape-revenge structure from which the revenge has been subtracted. Linda Williams showed that the "body genres", pornography, horror and melodrama, organise spectacle around a body beside itself in ecstasy, terror or grief, and that the body is usually female (Williams 1991). *Men* relocates the excess: it is men who convulse, scream and leak.

The comparative screen extends the argument.

- *Kind Hearts and Coronets* (1949): Alec Guinness plays eight members of the D'Ascoyne family, including its suffragette; a distant cousin murders six of them, the other two dying by accident and by shock, to avenge his disinherited mother and take the dukedom. It is the British precedent for one actor embodying an entire patriline, and its plot is a matrilineal revenge upon an agnatic line.
- *Rosemary's Baby* (1968): a husband, in exchange for his career, lets a coven drug his wife so that she can be raped and impregnated by Satan, and she bears the Devil's son. *Men* removes the womb from the conspiracy.
- *The Wicker Man* (1973): a police sergeant lured to an island is burned alive by its community as a sacrifice amid pagan pageantry. Adam Scovell's "folk horror chain" of landscape, isolation, skewed belief and summoning fits *Men* exactly (Scovell 2017); its folk is gender.
- *The Witch* (2015): a Puritan family disintegrates, the father killed by the goat Black Phillip and the mother killed in self-defence by her daughter Thomasin when she attacks her, and Thomasin ends by ascending into a coven, a lateral female community under a male devil's sign.

- *Midsommar* (2019): a grieving woman joins a commune whose women mirror her sobbing in a collective wail, a chorus of echoed grief; the commune drugs her boyfriend and coerces him into ritual intercourse to impregnate one of its women, and she, crowned May Queen, chooses him as its final sacrifice and smiles as he is burned alive. Harper's echo is a chorus of one, and her smile is not sacrificial.
- *The Invisible Man* (2020): an abusive partner fakes his suicide so that, invisible, he can stalk and terrorise the woman who left him; he murders her sister and frames her for the killing before she kills him. *Men* shows that a real or apparent suicide can serve the same function.
- *Titane* (2021): a woman who has killed several people, made pregnant by a car, passes as a grieving father's lost son; masculinity is a steroid-fed performance; and the father's love asks nothing of the body before him. *Titane* closes on a birth, the mother's death in giving it, and a child received with love; *Men* closes on love demanded after a birth. That the father's love is given to a killer sharpens rather than spoils the contrast: it is a love that presents no bill.

5.8 The logic of misogyny: Manne, hooks, Ahmed

Kate Manne distinguishes sexism, the ideology that justifies patriarchal norms, from misogyny, their law-enforcement branch: the system that polices and punishes women who violate them (Manne 2017). Women are positioned as owing men a range of feminine-coded goods, attention, affection, admiration, sympathy, care and love, and the withholding of these goods provokes punishment. James's arc is Manne's thesis as narrative. Harper proposes to withdraw her love; he threatens to kill himself, strikes her in the face and dies; and his death, ventriloquised by the village, enforces the debt. His final words name the good owed. Manne's framework renders the ending juridical rather than sentimental: the debt is being collected.

bell hooks argued that the first act of violence patriarchy demands of males is not violence toward women but acts of psychic self-mutilation upon themselves, the killing-off of their emotional lives, and that men consequently demand a love they have been trained to be incapable of giving (hooks 2004). Her love ethic, defining love as the will to extend oneself for another's growth, is the humanist-feminist counterweight to the film (hooks 2000). The split arm is psychic self-mutilation rendered somatic: the men of Cotson are mutilated before they

wound. hooks's hope that men can choose to change remains the film's unanswered question. James asks for love; he does not offer it.

Sara Ahmed's feminist killjoy is the woman who refuses to participate in the happiness of others when that happiness depends on her silence (Ahmed 2010). Her *Willful Subjects* (2014) opens with the Grimm tale of the wilful child, whose arm keeps thrusting up out of the grave until her mother strikes it with a rod. Ahmed reads the arm as the figure of a will that refuses to be buried, and allies it with feminist refusal. *Men* gives us the other arm. The arm thrust through the letterbox is the wilfulness of entitlement, the will that refuses to accept a refusal, and Harper's blade is the rod. But where the Grimm mother's rod restores order, Harper's knife does not end the will; it splits it, and the split arm keeps coming, through the boy and the vicar, until it gives birth. The entitled will cannot be buried. It reproduces.

5.9 Race, intersection and the limit of the figure

Kimberlé Crenshaw's theory of intersectionality, developed with particular attention to violence against women of colour, insists that race and gender do not compose additively but structure one another (Crenshaw 1989, 1991). The film's configuration requires that scrutiny. The only Black man in *Men* is the abusive husband whose death sets the plot in motion, and his wife and the village of his afterlife are white. Angela Davis traced the myth of the Black rapist, the fiction of Black male threat to white womanhood under which white mobs lynched thousands of Black Americans (Davis 1981); Ida B. Wells had shown as early as 1892 that a charge of rape was absent from most lynchings and false in many of the rest, a pretext rather than a cause (Wells 1892). American cinema's founding racist image is a white woman's fall. Flora Cameron leaps to her death from a cliff to escape Gus, a Black character played by a white actor in blackface whom the film presents as a would-be rapist; the Ku Klux Klan then lynches him, and the film celebrates the lynching as rescue. The image belongs to *The Birth of a Nation* (1915). *Men* opens with a Black man's fall. The film does not escape that history merely by inverting it.

The birth chain complicates the hazard. James is born from Geoffrey, from the white English patriarchal line of the shires, so that his violence is attributed to that lineage rather than to race: the film locates the source of the violence in the gentry, the church and the constabulary of rural England. Yet the solution generates a problem of its own. James's specificity is absorbed into a white patriarchal genealogy; he becomes the terminus of a line that is not his. A

universalising critique of masculinity can erase the racialised particularity of men's lives, which is precisely the move humanism made with "Man". The film's racial configuration is the point at which its critique of the universal is most exposed to the charge of reproducing one, and no reading that admires the film's structure should pass over it in silence.

Chapter Six

The Humanist Remainder

Man, Men and the Crisis of the Universal



Men is anti-humanist only in the sense that it exposes the masculine particular concealed in humanism's universal. Its deepest commitments, to the singular face, to the unprecedented birth and to a love that is given rather than collected, are humanist ones, and the film can be read as a demand that humanism make good on them.

6.1 Homo mensura and the chameleon

Protagoras's dictum that man is the measure of all things (Plato, *Theaetetus* 152a) used the sex-neutral *anthrōpos*; its Latin and vernacular afterlives did not remain neutral. Vitruvius's well-shaped man, *homo bene figuratus*, inscribed in the circle and the square (*De architectura* III.1), became in Leonardo's drawing of c. 1490 the emblem of humanist proportion: a single male body as the measure of the world. Rosi Braidotti reads the Vitruvian figure as humanism's normative template, male, white, European and able-bodied, against which every other body is measured as a deviation (Braidotti 2013). Kinnear's body is Vitruvian Man transposed to an English village, the one body by which the whole community is proportioned, reproduced at every station.

Pico della Mirandola's *Oration on the Dignity of Man* (1486) supplies humanism's decisive self-image. God gives Adam no fixed seat, form or function; he alone may shape himself, sinking to the brute or rising to the divine; and Pico

exclaims, *quis hunc nostrum chamaeleonta non admiretur*?, who would not admire this chameleon of ours? Humanist dignity is protean self-fashioning, the capacity Stephen Greenblatt traced through the culture of the Renaissance (Greenblatt 1980). Kinnear is Pico's chameleon rendered as horror. He can be landlord, priest, constable, publican, child and beast, and his mutability discloses not freedom but sameness. The figure who can become anything proves able to become only himself.

6.2 The Rights of Man and their remainder

The Declaration of the Rights of Man and of the Citizen (1789) universalised *l'homme*. Olympe de Gouges answered with a Declaration of the Rights of Woman and of the Female Citizen (1791), whose tenth article observes that woman has the right to mount the scaffold and must equally have the right to mount the rostrum; she was guillotined in 1793. Mary Wollstonecraft's *Vindication of the Rights of Woman* (1792) answered Rousseau's *Émile* (1762), whose fifth book educates Sophie for the pleasure and use of her future husband. Liberal-humanist feminism, from Wollstonecraft to Martha Nussbaum's capabilities approach (Nussbaum 2000), has demanded that the universal keep its promise: that "man" mean human.

Men stands at the point where that demand meets its resistance. Its title strips the universal back to its particular, and its narrative shows what the particular does when a woman claims the exit the universal promised her. Harper's request is liberal-humanist in form: to divorce, to leave, to dispose of herself. It is answered not by argument but by enforcement: by her husband's threat to kill himself and his blow to her face, and, after his death, by the vicar's blame, the naked man's pursuit of her and attempts to enter the house, and the vicar's attempted rape. The film locates the failure of the humanist universal not in its concepts but in the force that meets those who invoke them.

6.3 Second nature: existentialism, anti-humanism and natural history

Sartre's humanism held that for human beings existence precedes essence (Sartre 1946). *Men* appears to deny it, since its men seem to possess an essence, a single face. Lukács called the world of petrified social convention "second nature" (Lukács 1920), and Adorno's lecture "The Idea of Natural-History" (1932) theorised a dialectic in which the historical appears as nature and nature is revealed as historical. Monoprosopy is second nature visualised: an essence that is the

sedimented result of history. The birth chain runs from the Green Man, nature personified, to the institutional men, history incarnate, and shows them to be one face. Patriarchy presents itself as nature, while the "natural" man is already historical, the progenitor of the landlord and the constable. Adorno's naturalhistory is the precise philosophical form of the finale.

Heidegger's "Letter on Humanism" (1947) treated humanism as a metaphysics that fails to think the essence of the human. Althusser's theoretical anti-humanism and his theory of ideological and repressive state apparatuses offer a more serviceable instrument (Althusser 1965, 1970). The Kinnear figures are the apparatuses wearing a single face: the constable as the repressive apparatus; the vicar as the religious; the landlord as property and the economic base; the publican as the culture of the local; the boy as family and school. Each hails Harper, through the boy's slur, the vicar's accusation, the constable's condescension and Geoffrey's joke, and each hailing constitutes her as a particular kind of subject: the guilty woman. Interpellation is the film's dramaturgy.

Foucault closed *The Order of Things* (1966) with the prophecy that man, a recent invention, might be effaced like a face drawn in sand at the edge of the sea. *Men* offers the counter-image. The face of man is not effaced; every wave redraws it.

6.4 Arendt: natality without novelty

Hannah Arendt located the root of political action in natality: the fact that human beings are born, and that each birth brings into the world someone new, capable of beginning something unprecedented (Arendt 1958). Its correlate is plurality, the condition that we are all alike in being human in such a way that no one is ever identical with anyone who has lived, lives or will live. Arendt closes her account of action with the Gospel's glad tidings, "a child has been born unto us", as the ground of faith and hope in the world.

The finale of *Men* is natality's negation. Its births produce no beginnings, since each new man is the man before. Plurality without difference, natality without novelty: the births are anti-natal in the strict Arendtian sense, for what they bring into the world is not a beginner but a repetition. The horror is not that men give birth but that birth no longer guarantees the new. In that light the film's last image acquires its weight. Riley arrives pregnant: a birth still to come, from a woman, of a child whose face is not yet known. The film ends on the possibility of

natality restored to its source, and it leaves undecided, which is its honesty, whether that child will be a beginner or one more term in the line.

6.5 *Frankenstein* and the fantasy of redemptive love

Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein* (1818) is the humanist and feminist novel of motherless creation. Victor makes life without a woman; Ellen Moers read the novel as a birth myth, and Anne Mellor as a critique of the male usurpation of female generative power (Moers 1976; Mellor 1988). Its creature advances an argument that the film's last man compresses into a single word. Abandoned and wretched, he declares that he is malicious because he is miserable, and demands that Victor make him a female companion, promising that her sympathy will end his crimes. Victor begins the female and destroys her before completion. Shelley refuses the premise that a woman's love is the cure for a man's violence, and she makes the refusal legible by having a man tear the promised woman apart.

The creature's argument is the oldest literary form of the Owed Heart: my suffering obliges you to supply a woman's love, and if you withhold it, my violence is your responsibility. The fairy-tale tradition naturalised the argument in *Beauty and the Beast* (Villeneuve 1740; Beaumont 1756), where a woman's love transforms a monster into a prince. Angela Carter's "The Tiger's Bride" (1979) reverses it: Beauty does not cure the beast; she becomes one. Harper does neither. She declines the transformation's terms altogether.

6.6 The clone, the pregnant king and the conditions of horror

Never Let Me Go returns here as a humanist test case. Its clones prove their interiority through art and love, and the novel's horror lies in the world's indifference to the proof. *Men* reverses the experiment. Its men have no art, no gallery and no proof; they have only the font, and their interiority, if they possess one, is never displayed. They ask not to be recognised as persons but to be loved as husbands.

Ursula K. Le Guin's *The Left Hand of Darkness* (1969) contains the most famous sentence on male pregnancy in modern fiction: the king was pregnant. Her Gethenians are ambisexual, assuming sex only in a periodic phase, so that any of them may bear a child. In Le Guin the pregnant king is utopian defamiliarisation; in Garland the pregnant man is horror. The difference goes to the heart of this thesis. Male pregnancy is not horrific in itself. It becomes horrific under agnatic recursion, where it serves hierarchy rather than dissolving it, transmits a wound

rather than a life, and terminates in a claim. The horror is not in the body but in the line.

6.7 Posthuman, vegetal, pastoral

Donna Haraway's cyborg is a creature of a post-gender world that would not recognise the Garden of Eden and declines the origin stories of Western humanism (Haraway 1985). *Men* is obsessed with origins, Eden, the Green Man, the first birth, and its horror is the horror of origin stories taken literally. Haraway's later slogan, "Make Kin Not Babies!" (Haraway 2016), names the film's ethical alternative with uncanny exactness. Its men make babies, and only babies of themselves; Riley's arrival makes kin.

Braidotti's posthuman subject is a nomadic life organised around *zoē* rather than the Vitruvian template (Braidotti 2013). Michael Marder's plant-thinking finds in vegetal life a mode of being that is modular, non-individuated and iterative, and treats it as an ethical alternative to the bounded sovereign subject (Marder 2013); Emanuele Coccia argues that all life is a single life passing through metamorphoses, so that every birth is a continuation (Coccia 2016, 2020). *Men* shows the dark side of the vegetal turn: vegetal iteration captured by the same, the modular, the clonal and the metamorphic set to work reproducing one face. The Green Man is patriarchy's vegetal alibi, the naturalisation of a social line. The film does not refute vegetal multiplicity so much as show what must be wrested from it, through the echo and through kin, for a multiplicity that does not collapse into one.

Raymond Williams showed that the English pastoral is a structure of feeling that conceals property and labour behind an ever-receding golden age (Williams 1973). Harper flees the city for the country and finds the pastoral's property regime intact: she is a tenant, Geoffrey the landlord, and the countryside's peace is his. Mark Fisher defined the eerie as a failure of absence or a failure of presence, something where there should be nothing or nothing where there should be something (Fisher 2016). Cotson is eerie in both registers. The same face is present where difference should be, and women are absent where a village should hold them.

6.8 Levinas's face and the face that demands

Emmanuel Levinas made the face of the Other the origin of ethics: before any contract it commands that I not kill, and it obliges without limit (Levinas 1961). In *Time and the Other* (1947) he located alterity *par excellence* in the feminine;

Beauvoir rebuked him in a footnote to *The Second Sex* for writing from a masculine standpoint that forgets woman's own consciousness, and Irigaray later pressed the objection (Beauvoir 1949; Irigaray 1991). *Men* stages the crisis of the Levinasian face. Its single face has lost alterity, being everywhere the same, yet it still issues commands. James's wounded face on the sofa borrows the ethical authority of vulnerability to make a claim of possession. The infinite obligation Levinas located in the face is appropriated by the dominant party and presented to the subordinate as a debt.

Harper's non-absolution answers this without abandoning ethics. It insists that responsibility toward another is not servitude to him, and that a face's vulnerability does not entitle it to a woman's love. Judith Butler's account of grievability, the unequal distribution of public mourning that marks whose lives count (Butler 2004), clarifies the film's moral economy. Cotson grieves James through the vicar's reproach and through the men who carry his afterlife, while Harper's own injury, the blow James struck to her face, whose bloodied aftermath the film shows in its opening moments, is grieved by no one in the village. The humanist remainder the film exposes is this asymmetry: the universal's sympathy flows by default to the man.

Chapter Seven

Ianua Virorum

Toward a Theory of Agnatic Horror



The preceding chapters assembled an archive; this chapter converts it into a theory. *Men* is the paradigm of a mode of horror in which the monster is not a creature but a lineage, the male line reproducing itself without women, and whose final product is not a body but a debt.

7.1 The conceptual apparatus

The constellation method obliges the critic to build concepts from the configuration rather than impose them upon it. Seven concepts emerge from the configuration traced in Chapters One to Six: four that describe the structure the film depicts, one that names the heroine's response to it, and two that name the alternatives the film sets against it.

Concept	Definition	Locus in the film	Principal sources and analogues
Agnatic recursion	The reproduction of masculinity through the male line alone, without passage through the female body	The chain of births	Aeschylus's Apollo; Tertullian's traducianism; Augustine's seminal Adam; preformation; Math's judgement
Monoprosopy	The rendering of many men as a single face	Kinnear's roles	Nicene consubstantiality; Lacan's masculine universal; Freud's collective figure; Girard's monstrous double

Concept	Definition	Locus in the film	Principal sources and analogues
Ianua virorum	The male body as the gateway through which violence passes between generations	The letterbox, the split arm, the birth openings	Tertullian's *ianua diaboli*, inverted; the Sheela-na-gig, appropriated
The Owed Heart (*cor debitum*)	The demand for love in which the male line terminates: injury converted into debt, debt into female guilt	James's answer on the sofa	Nietzsche's *Schuld*; Mauss's potlatch; the Sacred Heart; Manne's owed goods
Non-absolution	The refusal of the sacerdotal role the debt assigns to the woman; neither forgiveness nor revenge	Harper's question; the axe held, its use withheld from view; her smile at Riley	Arendt and Derrida on forgiveness; Clover's Final Girl, declined
Acoustic parthenogenesis	A self-multiplication of the voice that harmonises rather than replicates	The tunnel echo	Ovid's Echo; Irigaray's two lips; Cavarero on the voice
Lateral kinship	A bond that runs across rather than down: chosen, female, non-genealogical	Riley's arrival	Haraway's kin-making; Iambe and Baubo; Carter's rescuing mother

The twelve theses that follow state the theory in compressed form. The sections after them elaborate its three most consequential concepts, the Owed Heart, non-absolution and counter-generation, before defining agnatic horror as a genre-mode and answering the principal objections.

7.2 Twelve theses on agnatic horror

I. *Men* is a genealogy, not an allegory. Its images do not stand for meanings; they descend from archives and carry their histories with them. The proper critical act is to trace their descent, as Chapters Two to Four have done, rather than to translate them into propositions such as "men are bad", which the film neither asserts nor needs.

II. The film's object is the plural of Man. It decomposes humanism's universal into its sexed particular and recomposes that particular as a universal, a single face. Its subject is neither all men nor some men but the operation by which a particular claims universality and a universality conceals its particularity.

III. Monoprosopy is consubstantiality made visible. One masculine substance appears in many *personae*. Butler described gender as a repeated stylisation of the body that congeals over time into the appearance of substance (Butler 1990); here

that account meets the Nicene *homoousios*. The "one substance" of masculinity is the effect of congealed repetition, and the film shows the congealment as a face.

IV. The film relocates the gateway. Tertullian's *ianua diaboli*, woman as the door through which death entered, is transferred to the male body. The letterbox, the split arm and the birth openings make man the door through which violence passes from one generation to the next: the *ianua virorum*.

V. Agnatic recursion is traducian. Masculinity propagates *per traducem*, by layering, clonally, from a vegetal exception, the wild man, through the child, the church and property to the intimate, the husband. The order of births parodies the evolutionary "march of progress" popularised by Rudolph Zallinger's illustration of 1965, here compressed into a single night. Civilisation is shown to be wildness in successive costumes.

VI. The births are fantasy and penance at once. They consummate the womb envy theorised by Horney and Bettelheim, and they transfer to the sons of Adam the curse pronounced upon Eve, as Math's judgement compelled the violators of Goewin to bear young. The film refuses to choose between the readings because the structure it depicts is both: the fulfilment of a wish and its punishment.

VII. What the line transmits is the wound. The ruptured arm and the broken ankle pass from James to the naked man and from him down the chain. Descent, as Foucault insisted, is inscribed on the body; here it is inscribed as injury. The male line holds property, name and law, but what it inherits is the wound beneath them.

VIII. The issue of the line is a claim, not a child. The chain of births ends not with an infant but with a grown man who, asked what he wants, answers that he wants love. Agnatic recursion's sole product is the Owed Heart.

IX. The Owed Heart is a Christological debt-form. It converts a threat of suicide, and then a death, into an unpayable obligation, as Nietzsche argued that Christianity converted God's self-sacrifice into infinite human guilt.

X. Harper's response is non-absolution. She asks the question the wounded man needs to be asked and declines to be its answer. She neither forgives nor avenges; she refuses ordination into patriarchy's priesthood of forgiveness.

XI. The film sets two counter-generations against the line. The tunnel's echo is a self-multiplication of the voice that harmonises rather than replicates; Riley's arrival is a kinship that runs across rather than down.

XII. Agnatic horror is a genre-mode. Its monster is lineage itself, and it is legible well beyond *Men*, from Ealing comedy to the Overlook Hotel.

7.3 The Owed Heart

The exchange on the sofa is the film's theoretical summit, and four traditions converge upon it.

The first is Nietzsche's. The second essay of the *Genealogy of Morality* derives guilt, *Schuld*, from debt, *Schulden*, and the moral relation from the commercial relation between creditor and debtor. Its climax is what Nietzsche calls Christianity's stroke of genius: God sacrifices himself for humanity's debt, the creditor paying himself on behalf of his debtor, out of love, Nietzsche adds with a sarcastic invitation to disbelief, so that the debt becomes unpayable and the guilt infinite (*Genealogy* II.21). James's threat to kill himself if Harper leaves is this operation in domestic form. The creditor's threatened suicide, offered in the name of love, renders the debtor's obligation infinite. Whether his fall was suicide or accident does not alter the structure, because the village completes it. The vicar is the collector, Nietzsche's priest (§3.7), and the chain of births is the debt's genealogy, the line through which the claim descends until it is presented in person.

The second is Mauss's. *The Gift* (1925) described the potlatch, in which wealth is destroyed to humiliate and obligate a rival, the destruction itself becoming a gift that cannot be matched. A suicide threat is a potlatch of the self: it stakes the giver's life to impose an obligation the receiver cannot discharge. Mauss emphasised that the gift carries a spirit that demands its return. The Owed Heart is the spirit of a gift that no one requested.

The third is devotional. In the visions reported by Margaret Mary Alacoque at Paray-le-Monial between 1673 and 1675, Christ displays his wounded heart and laments that, in return for his love, he receives chiefly ingratitude; the devotion that followed centred on acts of reparation and received magisterial form in Pius XI's encyclical *Miserentissimus Redemptor* (1928). The iconography is exact. The wounded man displays the wound and asks for love as reparation for the injury he has suffered. James on the sofa, his arm ruptured, is the Sacred Heart secularised. The Owed Heart is its domestic double, *cor debitum* beside *cor sacratum*: a wound converted into a claim upon another's love.

The fourth is the Grail. In Chrétien de Troyes's *Perceval* (c. 1180–90) the wounded Fisher King's land lies waste because the young knight fails to ask why the lance bleeds and whom the grail serves; in Wolfram von Eschenbach's *Parzival*

(c. 1200–10) the healing question is one of compassion, what ails you? Harper asks the question. Her "what do you want?" is at once the Grail question and Lacan's *Che vuoi*? (§4.6). In the romances the question heals the king and restores the land. In *Men* it elicits an answer that discloses what the wound wanted all along: not healing but a woman's love. Chrétien's grail is borne in procession by a maiden. The last man of Cotson asks Harper to be the vessel itself.

Kate Manne's inventory of the goods women are taken to owe gives the debt its social ledger (§5.8), and love is the premium good in that inventory. The Owed Heart names the moment the inventory is presented as a bill. It is therefore both the product in which agnatic recursion terminates and the hinge on which it depends. The line can reproduce bodies without women, but it cannot produce the love it requires; that must still be extracted from a woman. At the moment of its triumph, the fantasy of male self-sufficiency is revealed as total dependence relocated from the womb to the heart. This is the central claim of the thesis: patriarchy, in the image *Men* makes of it, is a self-reproducing system whose only output is a debt it assigns to women.

7.4 Non-absolution

Harper's response on the sofa has been read as weary acceptance, as ambiguous capitulation, or as the prelude to a violence the film withholds. This thesis names it non-absolution and distinguishes it from three neighbouring terms.

It is not forgiveness. Arendt treated forgiveness as the remedy for the irreversibility of action, the power that releases agents from the consequences of what they have done, and observed that we are unable to forgive what we cannot punish (Arendt 1958). Derrida argued that forgiveness worthy of the name forgives only the unforgivable and cannot be made conditional upon repentance without becoming a transaction (Derrida 2001). The vicar demands neither form. He demands that Harper accept an apology as a debt owed to the apologiser. Forgiveness in his sense is not a gift but a payment, and Harper declines to pay.

It is not revenge. The Final Girl's triumph and the rape-revenge film's reckoning answer violence with counter-violence, and so confirm the economy of exchange they appear to break (Clover 1992). Harper holds an axe through the births and on the sofa, and the film withholds whether she uses it. The withholding is the film's ethical statement. The question of violence is left outside the frame, and the frame holds instead a question asked and an answer heard.

Nor is it condemnation, absolution's simple inverse. Harper pronounces no verdict on James. She does something more radical: she declines the office. In

Catholic sacramental theology absolution is a sacerdotal act, pronounced by an ordained minister. The village has spent the film attempting to ordain Harper into a priesthood of forgiveness, the office of receiving male confession and converting it into grace: Geoffrey's joke assigns her Eve's part, the vicar's reproach assigns her the confessor's, and James's demand assigns her the work of reparation owed to the Sacred Heart. Her refusal is a refusal of ordination. She will not be the font, the Grail, the looking-glass or the confessor.

Non-absolution is therefore the refusal of the sacerdotal role the Owed Heart assigns to women: the role of converting male injury into male innocence through the medium of female love. It requires no violence and no verdict. It requires only that the debt go unpaid. Its signature is the film's final image of Harper: in the morning, smiling, not at James but at Riley. Lily's discarded gun in *Devs* was its prototype (§1.7); Harper is its fulfilment.

7.5 Counter-generation

Agnatic recursion does not go uncontested within the film. Two other modes of generation are set against it, quietly, at the beginning of Harper's stay and at its end.

The first is acoustic parthenogenesis. In the tunnel Harper sings, and her voice returns to her layered and harmonised by the score: a choir of one. This is a self-multiplication, formally kin to the men's, but it differs from theirs in every essential respect. It multiplies a voice rather than a body; it produces consonance rather than identity; and it wounds no one. Ovid's Echo was condemned to repeat the last words of others, whereas Harper's echo repeats herself, and the repetition becomes harmony. Adriana Cavarero has argued that Western philosophy devocalised the logos, privileging the seen and the conceptual over the embodied uniqueness of the voice (Cavarero 2003). Irigaray's two lips, the figure of a female self-relation that requires no mirror (§5.3), here find their acoustic form: a voice that touches itself.

The contrast with monoprosopy is complete. The men multiply an image and produce monotony; Harper multiplies a voice and produces polyphony. Specular androgenesis meets acoustic parthenogenesis, and the figure that screams and runs at her from the tunnel's far end is the line's first incursion upon the alternative.

The second counter-generation is lateral kinship. The film's last movement is horizontal. Riley, who has accompanied Harper throughout by video call, drives to Cotson and arrives in the morning, pregnant, to find her friend. Her arrival

neither rescues, for it comes too late, nor avenges; it witnesses and accompanies. This is kinship that runs across rather than down: chosen, female and non-genealogical. Haraway's slogan names it (§6.7), and the mother who gallops to her daughter's rescue in Carter's "The Bloody Chamber" anticipates it (§5.6).

The Eleusinian frame gives this ending its depth. In the Homeric *Hymn to Demeter* the grieving goddess sits unsmiling until Iambe's jests make her laugh; in the version Clement preserves, Baubo's display does the same (§2.4). The Sheela-na-gig on Cotson's font belongs to Baubo's lineage. In the film what breaks mourning is neither jest nor display but a friend's arrival, and Harper's smile answers it: the first smile of a Demeter whose grief the village had tried to convert into guilt. The font's female figure, appropriated by the men's bodies in the night, is reclaimed at dawn, not as an image but as a relation.

Two births frame the ending. The chain of male births in the house produces only repetition and a claim. The birth Riley carries is still to come, from a woman, its face unknown. The film does not say what that child will be. It says only where natality now resides.

7.6 Agnatic horror as a genre-mode

Agnatic horror may be defined by five criteria. Its monster is a lineage or line of succession rather than an individual creature. Within it, masculinity reproduces itself without, or against, the participation of women. What passes down the line is wound, violence or claim rather than life. A woman is positioned as the line's debtor. And the resolution turns on her relation to that debt.

So defined, the mode is legible across a wider corpus.

- *Kind Hearts and Coronets* (1949) is its comic form: a single actor embodies an entire patriline, and the narrative is a matrilineal revenge upon it (§5.7).
- *The Shining* (1980), from Stephen King's novel (1977), is its canonical form. The ghost of a former caretaker, who murdered his wife and two daughters with an axe and then killed himself, and who calls the murders "correcting" them, assures Jack Torrance that he has always been the caretaker. Jack then tries to murder his own wife and son with an axe, and the closing photograph from 1921 places him inside the line. The Overlook is an agnatic machine; Wendy survives by fighting off her husband rather than accepting the role of the corrected wife, and Danny escapes through the maze in which his father freezes to death.

- *Hereditary* (2018) is its inverted form: a cult founded by the family's grandmother brings about the deaths of her granddaughter, her daughter and her son-in-law so that her grandson's body can be given to a male demon, Paimon, as his host: a matriline labouring to deliver a king.
- *The Lighthouse* (2019) is its homosocial form: two keepers who both bear the name Thomas dissolve into one another in isolation; the younger, who confesses to having let a previous superior die, kills the elder and climbs to the lamp, a succession by killing that returns to Nemi; the only woman is a mermaid of their projection.
- *Annihilation* (2018) and *Men* (2022) are Garland's paired studies, the first in the register of refraction, the second in the register of descent.
- *Titane* (2021) is the anti-agnatic case: a gender-fluid kinship interrupts the line, and a birth is received with love rather than followed by a demand for it.

The mode is not confined to horror's monsters; it describes a structure that horror makes visible. Its political pertinence follows. Wherever institutions reproduce themselves through the succession of men, dynastic, ecclesiastical, corporate or military, agnatic horror names the residue of that reproduction: the debt it assigns to those excluded from the line.

7.7 Objections and replies

Essentialism. The film, it is objected, claims that all men are the same. The reply is that monoprosopy critiques the masculine universal rather than asserting an ontology of maleness. Its form indicts the structure of the "all" (§4.6) and implicates the spectator's Fregoli perception (§4.8), while the chain of births presents masculinity as reproduced through institutions, which is to say socially, and exposes how social reproduction disguises itself as nature (§5.1; §6.3). The only man in the film who does not wear Kinnear's face is James, and he is the line's product. That is the film's formal claim: within the regime it depicts there is no outside. The claim concerns a regime, not a sex.

Misandry. The film, it is objected, hates men. But its men suffer. The births are agony; the men are mutilated before they wound, in hooks's sense (§5.8); and the film is as much a theodicy of masculine suffering as an indictment of masculine violence. It does not exclude men from the human. It shows how a structure excludes them from the plurality that would make them persons.

Racial coding. The objection is conceded in part (§5.9). Attributing James's violence to a white patriarchal line mitigates the hazard without resolving it. A theory of agnatic horror must ask not only how lines reproduce but which lines are permitted to reproduce and which are absorbed.

Subjectivism. The objection that the film's events are Harper's projection was answered in §4.8: the subjective reading repeats the vicar's operation at the level of interpretation, relocating the problem from the men to the woman's perception of them.

Obviousness. The objection that the film is too obvious was answered in the Introduction. The obvious is the region of ideology, and the film estranges it by insistence. Agnatic horror's diagrammatic clarity is a property of the mode rather than a failure of the work: a line must be seen whole to be seen at all.

Conclusion

After the Fall, Before the Kin



Men ends where its theology began, at a house whose garden holds an apple tree, but the woman found there in the morning is no longer cast as Eve. This thesis has argued that the film shows patriarchy as a line able to reproduce everything except the love it demands, and that it sets against that line a woman who will not pay.

The argument proceeded genealogically. Chapter One read the Garland corpus as a typology of motherless genesis, in which *Men* removes the last external mediator and lets men reproduce themselves. Chapter Two reconstructed the iconography of the font, where the Green Man and the Sheela-na-gig flank a basin that Christian theology made into the womb of the Church, and where the Fourth Branch of the *Mabinogi* supplies the precise juridical form of the finale. Chapter Three traced the redistribution of the Fall through Tertullian's gateway, the traducian vine, Augustine's seminal Adam, Apollo's embryology and the priest who redirects ressentiment. Chapter Four read the births as the consummation of womb envy achieved through the liquefaction the armoured male body most fears, and read the film's single face through Freud's collective figure, Girard's monstrous double and Lacan's masculine universal. Chapters Five and Six measured the film against the feminist and humanist traditions it answers, and Chapter Seven drew the archive into a theory.

The thesis claims four contributions. The first is a reconstructed genealogy of the film's images: the font as *uterus ecclesiae*, the finale as traducianism made

visible, the Fourth Branch as the template of a penal male gestation, and the closing exchange as the convergence of Nietzsche's debt, Mauss's potlatch, the Sacred Heart and the Grail question. The second is a conceptual apparatus: agnatic recursion, monoprosopy, the *ianua virorum*, the Owed Heart, nonabsolution, acoustic parthenogenesis and lateral kinship. The third is a genremode, agnatic horror, whose monster is lineage itself and whose criteria hold across a corpus from Ealing comedy to the Overlook Hotel. The fourth is an ethics. Non-absolution names a feminist response to the male claim that is neither forgiveness nor revenge but the refusal of the sacerdotal office, and it is offered as a contribution to moral philosophy as much as to film studies.

The limits of the film, and of the thesis, must be stated as plainly. The racial configuration of *Men* places the only Black man at the origin of the violence and then absorbs him into a white genealogy, and no theory of the line fully redeems that arrangement. The film's form invites an essentialist reception that its structure does not support, and a film's invitations are part of its meaning. K. Austin Collins's complaint that the film attends more to its men than to its woman has force: *Men* knows the architecture of the line far better than it knows Harper's life, and a theory built upon the film inherits that asymmetry. This study's own limits are those of its archive, which is overwhelmingly European and Christian, and of its method, which treats most sources as analogues rather than causes and draws on no production records beyond the public filmography.

Four lines of further research follow. Agnatic horror should be tested beyond the Anglophone and European canon, where lineage, ancestor cults and dynastic succession take other forms. The vegetal dimension, from the Green Man and Blodeuwedd to the clonal vine and Haraway's kin, invites an ecofeminist study of how plant imagery naturalises patriarchal succession and how it might be made to denaturalise it. Garland's later work, from the all-male collective of *Warfare* to the onomastic cult of the Jimmies, should be read as the continuation of the inquiry *Men* brought to crisis. And the film's Fregoli effect, the spectator's perception of a single face where the heroine remarks none, invites empirical reception study of how audiences generalise, and resist generalising, about men.

In the Fourth Gospel Nicodemus asks whether a man can enter his mother's womb a second time and be born. *Men* stages the attempt to be born again without her and shows its result: a man cannot be born anew from himself, only born the same. The village spent a night telling Harper that she was the gateway through which death entered. In the morning the film shows her as the one figure in it capable of beginning, smiling at a friend who has come of her own accord, carrying a life whose face no one yet knows. That is where the film leaves natality,

and where this thesis leaves the theory it has drawn from the film: after the Fall, before the kin.

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Keywords



Alex Garland; *Men* (2022); agnatic horror; agnatic recursion; monoprosopy; *ianua virorum*; the Owed Heart (*cor debitum*); non-absolution; acoustic parthenogenesis; lateral kinship; folk horror; Green Man; Sheela-na-gig; wodewose; baptismal font; *uterus ecclesiae*; Tertullian; traducianism; Augustine; original sin; the Fall; autochthony; patrogenesis; preformation; womb envy; couvade; symbolic wounds; abjection; monstrous-feminine; monstrous-masculine; the uncanny; the double; sexuation; *Che vuoi*?; Echo and Narcissus; *Mabinogi*; Blodeuwedd; Female Gothic; Final Girl; male gaze; body genres; homosociality; monstrous double; scapegoat; misogyny; himpathy; coercive control; intersectionality; humanism; posthumanism; natality; vegetal life; Sacred Heart; Grail question; “Leda and the Swan”; genealogy; iconology; *Nachleben*